

The man who saved Maryborough Baptists – WT Godson

By Rev David Parker, PhD, February 2026 © revised July 2026

Introduction

The histories of the Baptists in Maryborough, in the Wide Bay region of Queensland, all speak of the dramatic establishment of the church in 1860 when Rev BG Wilson of the Wharf Street Baptist Church, Brisbane spent a few weeks in the town, formed the church and installed his young protégé, Josiah Thomas Hinton, as pastor. They go on to record that Hinton left for Rockhampton after only three years (and he was absent for more than a year during that time), leaving the church to fade away. They take the story up again about twenty years later when the church was reformed at the initiative of the Baptist Association of Queensland (which had only been formed in 1877), this time permanently, although not without more drama in its earliest months. It has faithfully continued its witness and ministry to this day.

But there is great deal more to the story of those intervening twenty ‘silent’ years than that – and it all revolves around a pastor who is largely unknown in Queensland, but one who heroically carried the Baptist flag in that burgeoning city even though he was then in his senior years, Rev William Theophilus Godson. Thanks to the availability of the local newspaper through the National Library of Australia’s Trove, and many other resources¹, his remarkable story can now be told!²

Background – Maryborough and the Baptists

In the early 1860s, Maryborough was a rising town in the Wide Bay district of Queensland, about 250km north of Brisbane, with a population of only around 700 (and about 4000 in the surrounding districts), and a key port for movement of goods, produce and people. However, access by land was difficult, requiring a journey via inland areas such as Nanango and Ipswich. This meant that the district, benefitting from a navigable river, relied extensively on sea travel.

The initial settlement, dating from the early 1840s, was about 10 km further up the river from the current city. However, as sea trade increased, and with it the size and number of the ships using the port, it was found that the original site was unsuitable, and so from 1856 the town was moved downstream to its present location. It was declared an official port of entry in 1859 resulting in the arrival of many migrants on their way to the promising districts and towns local and inland. The original site has been memorialised with suitable markers in the vicinity of Aldrige Street.³

It was not an easy city in which to plant a Baptist church, being described as ‘a mean and shabby looking town’, with its population seriously divided on social and economic lines, and ‘too few [of them] for peacefulness’ and with ‘far too little to do.’⁴ Even by 1864, the population was reported as only 1919, over who 118 were Baptist (nominal) and 358 Church of England.

However, seeing the strategic importance of the town, the enterprising pastor of the Wharf Street Baptist Church, Rev Benjamin Gilmore Wilson (1823-1878), who had a vision for planting churches in all the key towns of the colony, visited the town in April 1860. He took with him a young trainee pastor, Josiah Thomas Hinton (1833-1915), appointed him as ‘resident missionary’ and constituted a church.⁵ Hinton was a good choice for the position. Although only in his

¹ See end of paper for acknowledgement of sources.

² SW Nickerson, *Rev Benjamin Gilmore Wilson, Queensland Baptist Founding Father* (Baptist Historical Society of Queensland, 1998), pp 62-64, provides the best background on this matter, but he has little on the subsequent years. There are no papers from Hinton or the church from that period, but newspaper reports do provide some valuable information. See also notes in Acknowledgements below re information supplied by Celia Dodd and Jeanette Terry.

³ See Tom Blake and Richard Allom, *Original Maryborough Site – an historical study* (Maryborough City Council, 1988)

⁴ Rod Kirkpatrick, *Sworn to no master: a history of the provincial press in Queensland to 1930* (Toowoomba, Darling Downs Institute Press, 1984), p 31

⁵ There are no documentary records from this period of the life of the church. There is a list of donors to the building fund, but, typically, various members of the community would be included in this, not just members or supporters of the Baptist Church itself. (*Maryborough Chronicle, Wide Bay and Burnett Advertiser* (MC), 7 March 1861).

20s and not very experienced, he was the son of a prominent London pastor, and with Wilson's support, made a promising beginning, remaining the only Christian minister in the town for some time.⁶

Services were held at first in the Court House, but by early 1861, a prominent and elevated block in Lennox Street was purchased. It was at the current 242 Lennox Street, on the western side between Sussex and Walker Streets, opposite the current Queen's Park, and is now part of the Roman Catholic primary school, right at the pick-up point for children near the covered play area.⁷ A church was constituted with a foundation membership of five.⁸ A building fund was established which attracted a good response from donors.⁹ This location was later described as 'commanding a pleasant view both of the town and of the River Mary.'¹⁰ The wooden chapel was opened on 21 October 1861.¹¹ Hinton was also ordained by Wilson who was in the town on another of his many visits. Although progress seemed rapid, an announcement in the press soon after revealed that the financial support of the church was in a perilous state, with many promised donations having not materialised.¹²

Hinton had already involved himself in town affairs, such as serving on the committee for the local hospital, advocating for national education locally and supporting the newly formed School of Arts. On one occasion he expressed his keen disappointment that he was not called by the local authorities when there was a hastily arranged burial following a tragic drowning. He felt that, as the only Christian minister in the town and known as one who was always willing to serve the wider community, he had been seriously overlooked. He was, however, called to conduct another funeral of a shooting victim in December 1861.¹³ An interesting but perhaps little-known role for Hinton, drawing upon his earlier experience in the trade while living in Ipswich, was that of principal leader writer for a period for the *Maryborough Chronicle*, especially on Indigenous matters.¹⁴

In September 1861 he had also helped to further Baptist work with an extended visit to Gayndah to the west, paving the way for the settlement of Rev RR Wilson in that town.¹⁵ He supported his mentor and sponsor, BG Wilson, who conducted meetings in Maryborough in March 1862 in support of his Queensland Missionary Society, and also assisted him with promoting the temperance cause.

However, Hinton had apparently overworked himself, and was obliged to take sick leave after only seven months into the post, travelling to Brisbane in November 1860. He was probably under the care of Rev BG Wilson who was a practising qualified homeopathic practitioner. Hinton returned to Maryborough in early January 1861 and resumed his regular ministry. However, in mid-1862, his attention was directed to Rockhampton when Wilson had him visit that city, which was another promising centre where Wilson wanted to establish a church. Hinton was to assist in that

⁶ MC 4 July 1861. He conducted the first wedding reported in the initial edition of the *Maryborough Chronicle*, *Wide Bay and Burnett Advertiser*, 21 Nov 1861, p 2.

⁷ The church property was probably Section 68 Allotment 8, and the minister's residence was Allotment 9 (although the Paton document, 'The Baptist Church in Maryborough, Q Time Line', reverses these) which appears to be behind and adjacent on the north of the church block at the current 242 and 250 Lennox Street (Museum of Lands, Mapping and Surveying, Queensland Government, email 9 Jan 2026). Hinton also personally owned property in the vicinity – Section 67 Allotment 7, one block further north, on the west side of Lennox Street half way up from Walker Street towards North Street.

⁸ *The Australian Evangelist*, Nov 1862, p 358. Membership had reached 31 by the second anniversary, due in no small part to the evangelistic efforts of Hinton, but this was probably its maximum.

⁹ MC 7 Mar 1861. Although there was an appeal for people to honour their promises when actual contributions fell short of expectations. A report in the *Maryborough Chronicle*, 31 Oct 1861 stated that at the beginning of the year, it had become 'evident that the funds at disposal were utterly inadequate' to operate the church, so a public appeal was launched, in which £120 p.a. was promised, but only £58 had been received in the following 10 months. A £100 loan taken out at the time would stand for many years!

¹⁰ MC 2 June 1864

¹¹ MC 10 Oct 1861. A hand-written report by A Wilson, an early secretary of the Maryborough Historical Society supplied to the author by that society on 13 March 2026, records an eye-witness statement by the Misses Woodman whose forbears owned land where the Roman Catholic Convent stood, stating that the Baptist church was a 'slab-built building.' However, I am indebted to historian, Thom Blake, for the strong suggestion that the description of this church as a simple slab-built structure is not likely to be realistic. He points out (email 16 March 2026) that the cost (£265), the seating capacity of 120 (and order for seating (MC 25 July 1861) and the number and type of donors to the project suggest that it was a much more ambitious project, especially taking into account comparisons with other similarly conceived contemporary buildings. Furthermore, its use by many organisations throughout its life suggests that it was a desirable building to use, and therefore, of some quality.

¹² MC 19 Dec 1861

¹³ MC 4 July 1861, 12 Dec 1861

¹⁴ Rod Kirkpatrick, *Sworn to no master: a history of the provincial press in Queensland to 1930* (Toowoomba, Darling Downs Institute Press, 1984), p 32

¹⁵ David Parker, 'Baptists in Gayndah Queensland's oldest (?) town', 2025–<https://www.bhsq.org/pdf/Parker-Baptists-in-Gayndah.pdf>.

development, but events moved fast, and during his visit, the church was formed and the first baptism for the town took place. This was to be an ominous sign for the fortunes of the Maryborough cause.¹⁶

Then Hinton announced that he would be taking time off to visit England for personal reasons. Another Baptist minister, also formerly of Ipswich, Rev William Swain Roberts, became available to supply the pastorate for an extended time, so Hinton found that he could plan on being away longer than he had at first thought – up to a year. He was farewelled in September 1862, and by March 1863, news had been received of his safe arrival in London. As well as renewing ties with his family, he also got married while in London to Roberta Annie Swayne (of Liverpool). The couple arrived back in Queensland on 10 December 1863.

Hinton resumed his pastoral work at Maryborough, but made another trip to Rockhampton in June 1864. This was to be decisive. His final service at Maryborough was conducted on 25 August 1864, and the Hinton family departed on the next steamer to Rockhampton to lead the young Baptist church there. A son was born to the family in March 1865, but the conditions proved too trying for the health of Hinton's wife. They left Rockhampton in August 1865, moving to New South Wales, and then later to New Zealand where he and his wife had long and effective ministries. He died in New Zealand on 5 November 1915, as a well-respected senior Baptist pastor.

However, Rev WS Roberts, who had replaced Hinton in Maryborough during his overseas trip, also relinquished this position in March 1863. He had been very successful at Ipswich leading the church out of a low period, but he was overcome by illness at Maryborough.¹⁷ He entered the local newspaper business, becoming part-proprietor of the *Maryborough Chronicle*, a position which he held for many years.¹⁸ The paper had recently been sold by noted Baptist and community leader, CH Buzacott, to Roberts and Mr J Robinson.¹⁹ Over many years, Roberts became a well-known and appreciated figure in the town, but died suddenly on 10 Nov 1880, at 49 years of age. One report suggested that Roberts was too outspoken for the rather narrow-minded Baptists of the day, and that journalism suited him far better, since he held progressive views on both religion and politics.²⁰ He was buried as a 'free thinker, formerly Baptist' by the local Church of England minister.²¹

Roberts' departure from the leadership of the Baptist church in March 1863 meant that another pastor was needed until Hinton's planned return after several more months. Wilson was again able to supply someone for this position – in the person of Rev William Theophilus Godson. Although unknown in Brisbane and migrating on his own initiative, Godson, was already an older man with many years of pastoral experience. He had only recently arrived in Brisbane, and soon moved to Maryborough where he took over the leadership of the church. He remained in the town for more than 20 years, for most of the time as the only Baptist minister. He kept the cause going, although not in an orthodox manner, until a new effort was made in the early 1880s to establish a Baptist church which has continued until the present. Godson remained in the area until late in 1885 when he moved to Gympie, where he died in 1888.

WT Godson saves the day

Godson arrived in Brisbane on 5 March 1863 on the *Golden City* which, originating in Liverpool, had left Queenstown, Ireland on 13 December 1862. He travelled with his daughter from his first marriage, Anne.²²

The *Golden City* had been engaged as one of a large number of official migrant vessels as part of a government scheme to increase the population of the new colony of Queensland. It operated under the Roman Catholic Bishop Quinn's own Queensland Immigration Society. There was, therefore, a large complement of Irish Catholic passengers, 334 in number, with their own priest-chaplain, who boarded in Queenstown. The rest of the passengers, amounting to 200, had joined the voyage in Liverpool. During the journey, and after agitation by the non-Catholic passengers, Godson had become the much-appreciated semi-official Protestant chaplain. However, this development continually annoyed his Catholic counterpart who kept a close watch on the welfare of his flock to protect them from 'the Baptist minister', as his diary reveals.²³ If he needed to, this voyage must have introduced Godson to the realities of

¹⁶ David Parker, Editor, *Something More than Gold: Baptists in Central Queensland 1862-2012* (Baptist Heritage Queensland, 2012), 1-34

¹⁷ *The Australian Evangelist*, Oct 1862, p 308; May 1863, p 153

¹⁸ Rod Kirkpatrick, *Sworn to no master: a history of the provincial press in Queensland to 1930* (Toowoomba, Darling Downs Institute Press, 1984), p 33

¹⁹ Buzacott, and his brother William of Rockhampton, were both highly prominent in the newspaper, political and Baptist worlds. See Rod Kirkpatrick, *Sworn to no master: a history of the provincial press in Queensland to 1930* (Toowoomba, Darling Downs Institute Press, 1984), pp 30ff. See also Rod Kirkpatrick, 'Pulpit and press: early Baptists became pioneering newspapermen', *QB Forum* 110, Dec 2021, pp 6-7.

²⁰ *Darling Downs Gazette* 12 Nov 1880

²¹ Burial register, Maryborough Cemetery. Information on burials supplied by Dr R Smalley, Secretary, Maryborough, Wide Bay and Burnett Historical Society, 21 Nov 2025.

²² The shipping list has his daughter, Anne, erroneously as Mrs Godson, and also his age at 50.

²³ See Tom Boland, 'Life on the Ocean Waves: a chaplain's experience on one of Bishop Quinn's migrant ships', *Brisbane Catholic Historical Society*, 2006 Vol 10, Paper 3, 44-56

sectarianism in no small way. The press reports of the voyage also hint at an aspect of the situation that was described in the Catholic priest's diary.²⁴

Godson arrived in Brisbane completely unknown to any of the locals and without any pastoral prospects in view, but was welcomed as someone who could assist the small Baptist cause. He associated himself with the Wharf Street Baptist Church (established 1855), rather than the only other church in Brisbane at the time, Jireh Particular Baptist Church, which had been established only a year or two before his arrival. At Wharf Street, Wilson was struggling with his health and his leadership of the church. Therefore, he was pleased, at first, to have Godson assist him by supplying the pulpit.

Godson was also invited to preach at Ipswich Church, which had been pastorless since August 1862 when WS Roberts had left for Maryborough. Godson preached there on 5 April 1863. The church quickly took the opportunity to try to fill their long vacant pastorate by sending an urgent letter to Godson, inviting him to serve for a 12-month period. There was no immediate reply, but the church was soon informed that Godson had already gone to Maryborough to replace Roberts, and had in fact preached his first sermon there. He replied promptly to the Ipswich church from that city, explaining that he had been committed to Maryborough before his Ipswich visit upon the recommendation of Rev BG Wilson under whose advice Godson had placed himself. However, Godson did take the opportunity to inform the Ipswich church that he did not appreciate the 12-month condition on their call to him, or the fact that they had not indicated what salary they would offer - 'be it little or much'!

Family history

Godson was born in Knightsbridge, London on 1 March 1803, son of Hannah Godson of Blockley (born 1780). He was christened at St Margaret's Church, Westminster, as 'William' on 2 March 1803.²⁵ He was christened again on 24 July 1803 at Blockley Parish Church as 'Jesse'. There was no father's name recorded in either case, so he took his mother's surname.

The young Godson was brought up in Blockley, a town in the northern Cotswolds area of Gloucestershire where the family name went back to at least the 17th century.²⁶ This attractive town, famous for its silk industry, was the setting for the BBC TV series (2013+), *Father Brown!* Godson worked at least some of the time as a gardener, labourer and beer seller.²⁷ It is not known when Godson began his links with the Baptist Church, which had erected its first chapel in the town as early as 1792, which was replaced with a very 'conspicuous' edifice in 1835.²⁸ There is no information either about Godson's introduction to pastoral ministry.

On 25 December 1828, he married Hannah Clark in the Barcheston parish church in Warwickshire, about 15 km away.²⁹ Three children were born to the marriage while the family was resident at Blockley - Anne (2 July 1829), James 25 Nov 1830 (deceased 2 August 1837 due to measles), and Alfred 12 Nov 1833 (deceased about 1834).

No details have survived of the death of his first wife, but Godson married again in the fourth quarter of 1838 in the nearby Shipston on Stour registration district, bordering on Warwickshire, Gloucestershire and Worcestershire³⁰. His new wife was Elizabeth Davis (about 34 years of age). In the third quarter of 1841, a son, Theophilus, was born. Ten years later, in 1851, at the next census, the family was still at the same address. Anne was not with them (she was listed as a draper's assistant in a family tree³¹), but Theophilus was now aged 9 and a listed as a scholar.

However, there is some confusion over the name of the senior Godson. In his earlier years, he usually used 'Jesse' as his forename, although sometimes both were used, 'William Jesse', especially in more formal circumstances. However,

²⁴ *The Courier* 18 Mar 1863; *Queensland Guardian*, 10 Mar 1863

²⁵ He was probably christened in the workhouse where he was born, and an entry was made in the register of St Margaret's parish.

²⁶ <http://www.greatervancouverparks.com/Godson.html>

²⁷ In the birth certificates of his first three children at Blockley (1829-33), he is listed as 'labourer'. In the death certificate of James Godson, registered 9 August 1837 Blockley, and in the marriage certificate (3 Oct 1838) to Elizabeth Davis) he was listed as a 'gardener'. In Bentley's *Directory of Worcestershire* (1840) p 54 he is listed as a 'beer seller &c'.

²⁸ *Bentley's Director of Worcestershire*, 1840, p 53. In 1820, the Baptists of Blockley separated from the Campden church with which they had been members since its inception ca 1785 with Rev Daniel Wright as pastor. In the early nineteenth century, the Blockley church prospered with the growth of the local silk industry. A large chapel seating up to 500, named 'Ebenezer', was opened in 1836; in later years, it was praised for its architecture, and was in use until 1969 ('The Baptists in Campden and Blockley', transcribed by J Malin, Gloucester and Worcester Archives Offices, 2007, per Celia Dodd, 2026).

²⁹ She was named 'Annie' in the death registration of her daughter also named 'Annie'.

³⁰ The marriage took place at Ebenezer (Baptist) Chapel, Blockley (Celia Dodd, email, 11 Feb 2026)

³¹ Anne was living in Teme Street, Tenbury where the head of the household was Charles Preen, a hatter and draper. (Celia Dodd, email, 11 Feb 2026)

from the moment he stepped on-board the *Golden City* for the voyage to Australia, and throughout his entire life and ministry in Queensland, he was known as 'William Theophilus Godson', often abbreviated to 'WT Godson BM' (Baptist Minister). He was, however, buried as 'William Thomas Godson' (but that is no doubt due to confusion in the minds of those around him at the time over the abbreviation 'Th'). Although there is this change of name after his migration, church authorities in Wales certainly recognised 'W T Godson', the pastor in Queensland as the former pastor in their district when they supplied written evidence to vouch for his integrity when it was questioned in late 1864.³²

A senior pastor

Godson was 60 years of age when he arrived in Queensland, confirmed by the fact that his 70th, 74th and 80th birthdays were enthusiastically celebrated in Maryborough in 1873, 1877 and 1883,³³ although the passenger list of the *Golden City* had him as only 50 years of age in 1863. His 70th birthday was also said to be a celebration of his 40th year of ministry, but this seems too much, as the commencement of his ministry can only be traced to about 1841, making it more like 30 years. However, it is likely that he was active as a lay-preacher or even lay-pastor in those earlier years.

Even so, he was a much more senior pastor than any of the others who served in the Wide Bay area at the time – WS Roberts, JT Hinton, and RR Wilson. He was certainly much senior to BG Wilson, born 1823, who had arrived in Queensland in 1858, and who regarded himself as the (Baptist) 'apostle to Queensland'. He had only commenced his ministry in 1851, but simply as a town evangelist and then as a church pastor at Barnsley late in 1854. This gave him just 12 years of experience at most, and barely four as a pastor. He had only been a Baptist for a few years.

However, there is still the question of why Godson, at the age of 60, did migrate to the other side of the world without his wife and leaving behind his son (now safely married, albeit as a minor), taking only his daughter from the previous marriage, and changing his forename as well! Surprisingly for someone with such a long and varied pastoral history in the homeland, there are no recorded farewells upon his departure. There seemed to be no call or invitation from Queensland – he travelled at his own initiative.

The circumstances of his pastorate at the time, Ebbw Vale, a harsh industrial centre and tense with politics, may have contributed. However, a written history of the church there notes the surprise of the congregation at the time at his sudden removal and subsequent 'disappearance'.³⁴ And far from giving any hint of difficulties, the document reported that the church had flourished during his short time with them.

Emigration was certainly in the air, not least in Ebbw Vale, for Catholics³⁵ and for Protestants as well, and would have presented a viable option for someone who wished to make a new start, even if he was an older person and not an industrial worker.

For whatever reason, this was apparently the only viable future that Godson could see for himself—a change of country, a partial change of name and a new start! It would certainly be a vastly different life for him over the next 25 years!

But the reality is that at this stage in his life, Godson was largely on his own, his first wife having already died (and it was her daughter, the only surviving child, who accompanied him). Perhaps some breakdown in his second marriage or other reasons unknown (such as health), meant that Elizabeth decided not to travel with him. Yet in 1871 she is in Blockley with her brother Thomas Davis, and then in 1881, she is with her younger sister Mary as a 77-year-old annuitant in Worcester Broadway. Her death was recorded in Shipston 1891 at age 89 years.

Their only child, Theophilus, a grocer of Bedwelty, was off his hands because he had already married Clare Eleanor Stocker (on 12 May 1862) at Edgbaston, a prosperous suburb of Birmingham. This son, Theophilus, grew to have a successful life and left a large amount of property in his will.³⁶

Godson's grandson (by Theophilus), William James Godson came to Queensland in 1874 while only 10 years old³⁷ and lived for a time in the Maryborough area. In 1880 there was a court case where he was accused of taking a horse from David Philip White, husband of his aunt Anne, after which he had absconded. He married in Brisbane in 1888, and there are records of him enjoying a full and varied life thereafter, including serving in the Boer War before finally settling Canada. There are also references to a 'Mr W Godson' in 1884 in cycling news locally.³⁸

³² MC 25 Aug 1864

³³ MC 27 Feb 1873, 24 Feb 1877, 1 Mar 1883

³⁴ Zion Baptist Church, *150 History*, 1846-1996, p 8

³⁵ See Tom Boland, 'Life on the Ocean Waves: a chaplain's experience on one of Bishop Quinn's migrant ships', Brisbane Catholic Historical Society, 2006 Vol 10, Paper 3, 44-56

³⁶ Email, Jeanette Terry, 23 Nov 2025. His will included references to rents from various properties, land holdings, and cash.

³⁷ MC 30 Nov 1874

³⁸ MC 1 July 1884, 1 Oct 1884, 7 Oct 1884

So Godson was not only 20 years senior to Wilson in age, but he was much more experienced pastorally. After all, he had served in three churches in UK over at least a 20-year period before emigrating, and the leadership of his last church had said that ‘Mr Godson brought a first-rate character as a Christian minister of long standing’ when he had arrived at the church.³⁹

Tenbury 1840-1852

First of all, he was pastor from about 1840 in Tenbury where he was instrumental in re-opening the chapel and leading the congregation with good acceptance for more than a decade. Tenbury was an attractive market town and fruit growing area in the extremity of the Malvern Hills, Worcestershire, some 50 km from Blockley, Godson’s home town, and 65 km south west of Birmingham. ‘Wells’ was added to the town name in the 1840s while he was resident there because of the discovery of mineral springs in 1839 which was to attract much attention and prosperity for the town in later years. It is said that Queen Victoria, who visited the town in the late 19th century, referred to it as ‘my little town in the orchard.’

The Baptist church had begun there in 1819, and used Goff’s Free (charity) School in Cross Street for its services⁴⁰ (now the site of the museum). The teacher of the school also served as the Baptist pastor. After difficult times at first, the church prospered for many years, but by the late 1830s, it had encountered more pressure. Godson was a welcome arrival to lead the church into better times once again.

Godson was listed in the 1841 census as a 35-year-old preacher living in Tenbury with his wife Elizabeth and daughter Anne, residing in Cross Street. He was inducted into the position on May 18, 1842 ‘having previously exercised his ministry among them for some months with acceptance’.⁴¹ Church minutes indicate that he began his ministry in 1840. His daughter Anne was baptised on 19 May 1850 and joined the church, while a month later, on 2 June, there was a baptism of four people in the local river.⁴² He concluded his ministry there on 10 October 1852. A new building was opened in 1855, with Godson having delivered an ‘able address’ at the laying of its foundation stone.⁴³

Evenjobb and Gladestry 1852-59

In the second half of 1852, probably in August, he moved 40 km to the rural area of Radnorshire in Wales, where for seven years he served the English-speaking Baptists in the villages of Evenjobb and Gladestry, a few kilometres apart. The Zion Baptist church was located in Gladestry, and at Evenjobb, it was the Bethel church. Non-conformist churches like the Baptists were strong in the area, and he was involved in many inter-church and district Baptist activities, and had a reputation as a fine preacher.

Ebbw Vale 1859-1862

In August 1859 he moved again, this time about 60 km south into the heart of the Welsh mining area at Ebbw Vale.⁴⁴ It had once been a quiet rural area, but by then was a congested, noisy and dirty industrial centre famous for its massive iron and coal production. Later, steel from its mill was used to construct the Sydney Harbour Bridge, and its steel works would become the largest in Europe. It was also a hot-bed of radical politics.

He pastored the English-speaking church here from August 1859, which was located in Zion Street, Briery Hill and also known as Zion Baptist Church. The church stood in this very small area well away from mining and industrial parts of the town in the section where individual non-company homes were authorised, but there were no properly formed streets or other amenities. It was also the area where inns and beer houses were permitted, and it was reported that there were about 25 in such a small area, with the church in the midst.⁴⁵ The church reported a strong boost in membership upon Godson’s arrival, and many baptisms.⁴⁶

³⁹ MC 25 Aug 1864

⁴⁰ The building on the same site, since 1977 as the museum, was erected in 1863. The benefactor, Mr Edward Goff, was a philanthropist and active member of the Baptist Church. (Information supplied by Tenbury Museum, <https://www.tenburymuseum.org.uk/>, 12 Jan 2026)

⁴¹ *Baptist Magazine*, page 433, 1842

⁴² Information supplied by Tenbury Museum, 4 Jan 2025.

⁴³ *Hereford Times*, 17 June 1854. This building, on the corner of Cross Street and Berrington Road, and featured an indoor baptistry. The church closed in 1948, and the building has been used for various commercial and community purposes since. (Information supplied by Tenbury Museum, <https://www.tenburymuseum.org.uk/>, 12 Jan 2026)

⁴⁴ *Christian World* 11 Nov 1859; see also *Pontypool Free Press*, 12 April 1862; *Merthyr Telegraph and General Advertiser*, 11 Oct 1862, which said that the sermons of Godson *et al* were ‘remarkably good.’

⁴⁵ Paper, Jeanette Terry, 19 Sept 2004, privately communicated to author, 2025.

⁴⁶ Zion Baptist Church, *150 History*, 1846-1996, p 8

Here his reputation as a first-rate preacher was sustained, and he was active in supporting other existing and new Baptist churches in surrounding areas. He also owned some leasehold and other property in the parish of Bedwelty, hamlet of Manmoel, Tredegar Polling District, which entitled him to a vote.⁴⁷

Godson served here until he migrated to Queensland at the end of 1862. Little did he know that he would not escape altogether the industrial landscape of Ebbw Vale because Maryborough in Queensland would take on some of that atmosphere as it grew into a larger city famous for its manufacturing industries – although not at all to the proportions he had left behind!

Early ministry in Maryborough

Godson arrived in Maryborough on the *Clarence* on 15 April 1863, and soon took over pastoral duties at the Maryborough Baptist church, as arranged by Rev BG Wilson. He was registered by the Government to conduct marriages on 9 May 1863, and his first reported ceremony was conducted on 1 June 1863, the initial one of a very large number. This was a ministry for which he was to become well known. A social event to raise funds for the church building took place on 2 July 1863.⁴⁸ This served as a good opportunity for Godson to become acquainted with the people of the church and community.

This interim ministry was due to continue until December 1863. At this time, Rev JT Hinton resumed his pastoral role which continued until August 1864 (although there was short break when he made another brief visit to Rockhampton in June 1864).

As SW Nickerson has pointed out, Godson, being aware that his ministry at Maryborough would, in all likelihood, be restricted to these few weeks, began looking around for other places in which to serve.⁴⁹ He contemplated Port Denison (Bowen), about 1000 km north. This was the northernmost settlement in the colony at the time, where European settlers had only arrived as recently as 1860. The town was in its very early stages of development, and there was probably no other church there at the time, although other denominations were about to establish their presence in the district.⁵⁰

However, on 28 August 1863, BG Wilson penned a letter to Godson, forbidding him to pursue this option. It said,

As to your going to Port Denison this will reach you in time to caution you against the step of going into the ministry there, for the simple fact is you cannot be registered without reference to myself, and your name is already struck off the list of Baptist ministers [recognised by the government], if you attempt to officiate as such, the fine is £500, and two years' imprisonment.⁵¹

There is no evidence to suggest that Godson actually visited Port Denison at this time, and a Baptist church would not be established in that city until more than a century later, in 1978.

Rev JT Hinton was due to return to Maryborough not long after, and resume his role as Baptist minister, but it is not known if the local people would have known about his impending arrival.

Tension between Wilson and Godson

There was more to this issue, because in October 1863, BG Wilson told the Wharf Street church that he had received a letter from Wales accusing Godson of serious impropriety regarding some financial affairs while was a minister there. Wilson asserted that this information rendered Godson unfit to be a pastor. He also advised the Brisbane church that had already shared this information with the Baptists of Maryborough!

The lay leaders of Wharf Street took a cautious view of this news, and a letter was sent to the Baptist authorities in South Wales seeking clarification. At a meeting of the church on 4 December 1863, a reply was received clearing Godson of any wrong doing, and instead, commending him highly and expressing his former church's complete confidence in him.⁵²

If Wilson thought this episode would have provided the proverbial 'smoking gun' to discredit Godson completely, and allow him to continue to assert his dominance of the Baptist scene in Maryborough, he must have been sadly disappointed. It worked out quite differently. In fact, leading layman, TB Stephens blamed Wilson's intemperate actions

⁴⁷ Register of persons entitled to vote, Tredegar Polling District, 1863-1864. The 1861 Census shows his address as Manmoel, Bedwelty, Monmouthshire (Biographical note compiled by Jeanette Terry, 19 Sept 2004).

⁴⁸ MC 2 July 1863, 16 July 1863.

⁴⁹ Nickerson, *Wilson*, p 63

⁵⁰ *Bowen 1859-1865*, Bowen Historical Society and Museum, n.d.

⁵¹ Portion of letter reproduced in Joshua Jenyns, *Fruit from the Tree of Experience* (Baptist Historical Society of Queensland, 1996) p 9 in a printed letter from TB Stephens to the Members of the Wharf Street Baptist Church, dated 31 Mar 1864.

⁵² Extracts of a letter from the Baptist minister at Tredegar, South Wales dated 17 Jan 1864 clearing and commending Godson were published later in the *Maryborough Chronicle* on 27 Aug 1864.

with regard to Godson as having split the church at Maryborough, and causing the initial, much lauded, effort under Hinton and Roberts to fail.⁵³

In the circumstances, however, it is not difficult to understand the sudden and complete change of attitude by Rev BG Wilson and his bitter attitude to his fellow-pastor who was so much his senior. After all, records of the Wharf Street church at this time indicate that Wilson was facing severe health issues and internal resistance to his ministry. In fact, he was ready to resign his post, which must have been a devastating prospect for such an ambitious pastor, and one so enamoured of the idea of being the (Baptist) 'apostle to Queensland'. Furthermore, in the following year, 1864, there was a serious split in the church over Wilson's leadership and ministry practices. Wilson may have excelled as an evangelist and public figure, but as a pastor and church administrator, he had severe limitations.⁵⁴

Although hurt by Wilson's intervention, Godson was resilient. He published a frank notice in the *Maryborough Chronicle* on 3 December 1863 (the notice was dated 4 Nov 1863) in which he stated that 'Notwithstanding the injury ... through misrepresentation and insult', he was 'still eligible to officiate as the Baptist Minister of Maryborough' and would be conducting services in ET Aldridge's store in Ellena Street twice each Sunday, also with two Sunday School sessions. Despite BG Wilson's threat of legal action, which of course had little authority, Godson's press notice assured readers that he would still solemnise marriages - either at his home for one guinea, or a minimum of two guineas elsewhere! The basic fee was still the same twenty years later!

Hinton returned to Maryborough in December 1863, but this did not mean that Godson ceased his ministry. It was reported that there were regular communion services and prayer meetings during the earlier part of 1864,⁵⁵ and he conducted a baptism in April 1864. Anniversary services took place in the Lennox Street Chapel on 19 May 1864.⁵⁶ Hinton was still (nominal) pastor at this time (although he would be away again in Rockhampton for a short time the very next month, in June, and would depart permanently in August). But there was no pastor's name mentioned in the publicity for the anniversary, possibly indicating uncertainty about the situation.

Later in the year, in October, after Hinton's departure, Godson was advertising regular services in the School of Arts⁵⁷, including a collection in aid of the local hospital fund.⁵⁸ In April the following year, 1865, he conducted a funeral service in the same building.⁵⁹

There is no information about services in the next two years, 1866 and 1867, or early 1868. But in October 1868, Godson was advertising services at the School of Arts again, with a short break in November so that he could supply the pulpit at the Presbyterian Church. He soon resumed the Baptist services, on 10 December with a bonus lecture (and discussion) after the service on the topic, 'Baptismal regeneration, as adopted by Protestant Churches, an Awful Delusion'.⁶⁰ The timing and topic of this discussion raises a question - did something he saw in his brief time with the Presbyterians stir him up to think about baptism? This was an issue that would pre-occupy him again much later in life.

So, in the absence of Hinton the appointed pastor, Godson had taken over the services. There was some overlap with the ministry of Hinton in his closing days in Maryborough, which might have seemed that Godson seized the pastorate to the exclusion of Hinton, its apparently rightful occupant. However, as an experienced pastor, Godson would no doubt have been able to interpret the situation. Hinton had been away for long periods at various times, and the pastoral arrangements made by BG Wilson were flimsy, to say the least. Wilson had in fact long since withdrawn his interest from the church, stating that he could no longer offer it moral or financial support. He made no effort to arrange for continuing pastoral supervision after the Roberts' period.⁶¹

Godson could easily see that Hinton would not survive much longer, especially when his wife's poor health became an issue. So he simply stepped in to do what any senior pastor would do to save the day for the Baptist cause as best he could! He found himself, providentially, in Maryborough, so far from his original home, to take the lead and respond to the necessity created by the inability of Wilson to sustain his church planting program which was ruled mainly by impetuosity. The unsuitability of the inexperienced, albeit dedicated and talented, Hinton was also another inescapable

⁵³ See Stephens, in Jenyns, *Fruit from the Tree of Experience*, p 9

⁵⁴ Bill Hughes, 'The Wharf Street Dispute of 1864', *QB Forum* Aug 2013, No. 85, page 2. However, others had a different view of Wilson. See George E Loyau, *History of Maryborough*, (Brisbane, Pole, Outridge & Co, 1897), p 36, who described him as 'a kind and thoroughly unbiassed man', but it might be expected that he would support Wilson because he had been married by him (MC 22 May 1862)

⁵⁵ MC 5 May 1864

⁵⁶ MC 28 April 1864

⁵⁷ The original School of Arts building, located on the south-west corner of Adelaide and Kent Streets, was erected in 1861, and it was replaced in 1887 on the adjacent block north-west. The original building was opened at almost the same time as the Baptist church (MC 17 Oct 1861).

⁵⁸ MC 1 Oct 1864, 23 Nov 1864

⁵⁹ MC 29 April 1865

⁶⁰ MC 15 Oct 1868, MC 3 Nov 1868, MC 10 Dec 1868

⁶¹ MC 24 Oct 1861; he did make a mild effort to assist again in 1866, but it amounted to nothing (Nickerson, *Wilson*, p 64)

factor. Wilson seemed to be only interested in ‘flying in’ to start a church, but much more was needed to sustain one once started. Of course, Godson struggled to put in place a stable set of arrangements over the ensuing period, but at least he would become a well-known and mostly well-appreciated Baptist presence in the town for next two decades until another church could be started!

So the Baptist church which had been pioneered by Wilson and Hinton in 1860, based at the chapel in Lennox Street and which had opened with a fanfare, floundered after only a short time, despite Hinton’s promise that he would spend the rest of his days in Maryborough as pastor of the church.⁶²

There appeared to be some feeble efforts to revive it in subsequent years. Through the influence of Rev BG Wilson, Rev Thomas Hamilton, from Fitzroy Baptist Church in Melbourne, was advertised to be preaching at the Lennox Street church on 6 August 1865, about a year after Hinton’s departure. At the time, he was under the care of Wilson’s homeopathic services, as were, reportedly, several other people in the district.⁶³

Soon after, in September 1865, there was a notice informing residents that the well-known Strict and Particular Baptist minister from the south, John Bunyan McCure, would visit the city. No indication is given of where he would speak. He does not appear to have had any links with the existing Baptist church or with Godson.⁶⁴

Then in March 1868, Rev JJ Westwood was advertised to be preaching at the Lennox Street church on ‘the End of the World’, and conducting an open-air service on the river bank near the Post Office. He had been itinerating around the country for a decade, and would stay only briefly in Maryborough.⁶⁵

Godson as ‘the Baptist minister in Maryborough’

There were no other reported efforts to revive the original Baptist church in Maryborough until around 1880, but in the meantime, Godson continued to exercise a ministry as best he could in a bewildering variety of circumstances. He became known and widely appreciated as ‘the Baptist minister in Maryborough’ and kept the Baptist work going until he reached his very senior years, when it was able to be re-established in a permanent form. There are no church records from this time, the niceties of church constitution and governance being not applicable in the conditions.

Early in 1871, Godson announced that he would attempt to re-open the Lennox Street chapel which, after more than 10 years since its construction and several years of neglect, was in need of repair.⁶⁶ There was still a £100 debt on the project (unchanged for 10 years!). It was probably still the ‘gloomy’ and unpainted building that Rev BG Wilson complained about,⁶⁷ so Godson said that he would take no salary until the debt was cleared. English and German services were being conducted twice each Sunday.⁶⁸ Rev RR Wilson, formerly pastor at Gayndah Baptist Church, closed down by this time, was announced as a preacher there in March 1871.⁶⁹

One notable event during this period was a public baptism ‘to the astonishment of many spectators’ (as the press reported) in the ‘old clay pit’ in the Corporation (Municipal) Quarry across the road from the chapel – the pond in the current Queen’s Park. A German couple were the candidates. The report said that there was ‘some shallow water and plenty of mud, the latter of course clinging tenaciously to the garments of the converts.’ This was an event to be remembered well into the future.⁷⁰

There must have been some encouraging growth and consolidation, because by the end of 1872, Godson announced that there would be a meeting at the Lennox Street chapel to discuss the formation of a ‘Church on Baptist principles’.⁷¹ The date set for its official constitution was 31 October 1872, with a communion service to follow on 3 November 1872, and it would be known as ‘Maryborough Baptized Church’.⁷²

However, in a surprise move, instead of it taking place at the Lennox Street chapel, it was then announced to be held at ‘the Baptist Meeting House’ in John Street, Godson’s own home. Future services would also be held there! A Sunday School was formed at the same time.⁷³ In October 1872, a description of the town mentioned that the Baptists had a ‘neat chapel’ but its location or other details were not given – perhaps it was the John Street building.

⁶² MC 11 Sept 1862

⁶³ MC 5 Aug 1865

⁶⁴ MC 13 Sept 1865

⁶⁵ MC 14 Mar 1868

⁶⁶ MC 21 Feb 1871

⁶⁷ MC 23 Oct 1862

⁶⁸ MC 9 Mar 1871

⁶⁹ MC 23, 25 Mar 1871

⁷⁰ *Queensland Baptist* Jan 1892, *Gympie Times*, 2 Dec 1871

⁷¹ MC 5 Oct 1872, 12 Oct 1872

⁷² MC 29 Oct 1872

⁷³ MC 9 Jan 1873

Godson was now held in very high esteem, as indicated by the fact that two events were held in his honour. The first was held at the John Street chapel on 25 February 1873 to mark his 70th birthday. He was presented with a handsome illuminated address 'in recognition of his services as a minister of the Gospel'.⁷⁴ It was also what was said to be the 40th year of his ministry, although that dating was probably not accurate. Then later the same year, on 7 October 1873, another gathering was held, this time at the Temperance Hall⁷⁵ with the 'PROCEEDS intended to supplement a PRESENTATION to their Minister, W T Godson BM, as an expression of respect and esteem.'⁷⁶

About 300 people participated, and under the chairmanship of Mr WA Holme, heard speeches of appreciation and witnessed the presentation by Mr Negus, deacon, of a watch, spectacles and purse of money 'in a handsomely mounted box, as a token of their love to him and his fidelity to the church.' Godson responded by stating that he had received more money that evening 'than for seven years before' and that 'how much beyond his expectations was the sympathy that existed towards him in his old age.'⁷⁷ Another report stated that the presentation was also in 'acknowledgement for his gratuitous services to the church during the last twelve months', although earlier information suggested that this period actually began early in 1871, making it more like almost two years! There was also an address by Rev Mr Parkinson (Wesleyan) and a musical program to end the evening.⁷⁸

The Lennox Street chapel

Meanwhile, the Lennox Street chapel was still in use by a number of different organisations, although its ownership is unclear. It hardly seemed likely that there was any remaining Baptist organisation to manage it.

For example, the Rechabites were using it in September 1874,⁷⁹ and a month later the Primitive Methodists had hired it for Sunday services which may have continued until, or resumed as late as, August 1875.⁸⁰ In 1876, the Hand in Hand Good Templar lodge meetings were advertised for that venue and the Hope of Maryborough Good Templars were meeting there in September 1876.⁸¹

At the same time, the Orange Lodge was hiring it for their meetings, although they were about to open their own hall on the corner of John and Alice Streets. However, evidence presented in a legal case in March 1878, indicated that the chapel was still being occupied by the Orangemen at the time.⁸² A letter written in 1968 addressed to the Maryborough Historical Society suggests that it at some unspecified time it had passed into the hands of a pair of local businessmen, William Barnes, Solicitor, and F. Bryant, Agent.⁸³

But in March 1877, a notice appeared stating that the Baptist services would now be transferred to the 'NEW HALL, near the Primary School'.⁸⁴ This has been identified as the Good Templars Hall,⁸⁵ which was opened 26 January 1877. A Sunday School also operated for children, although its location was not clear.⁸⁶

This location was not long sustained because in April 1878 the services were advertised as having reverted to the Baptist House of Prayer in John Street.⁸⁷ This is soon after reports of a slander case against Godson were being published, in which it was stated numbers of attendees and support for the church had fallen right off. The House of

⁷⁴ MC 27 Feb 1873

⁷⁵ The Temperance Hall was located in Richmond Street, on the western side, not far from the corner of Alice Street going north, and was opened on 28 January 1872.

⁷⁶ MC 2 Oct 1873

⁷⁷ MC 9 Oct 1873

⁷⁸ However, it is difficult to reconcile these warm expressions of appreciation with other reports given at a court case in 1878 (MC 21 Mar 1878) that indicated a severe downturn in the life of the church about this time, and of Godson's reputation. Perhaps these marks of appreciation of Godson were efforts by his loyal supporters to mitigate the effects of his opponents. See more below under 'The Cane scandal'.

⁷⁹ MC 12 Sept 1874

⁸⁰ MC 3 Oct 1874; 24 Aug 1875

⁸¹ MC 13 June 1876), 5 Sept 1876

⁸² MC 26 Sept 1876, 21 Mar 1878

⁸³ Letter from MC Ruhle, Secretary, Star of the East Lodge, Mar 1968 supplied by Dr Roy Smalley, Honorary Secretary, Maryborough Wide Bay & Burnett Historical Society, 11 Dec 2025. Council rates information supplied by Dr R. Smalley. The building was not used when the Baptist church was reformed in 1883 (if it even existed at the time – ND Paton 'The Baptist Church in Maryborough, Q Time Line' claims it had disappeared by this time), but another property was soon obtained.

⁸⁴ MC 3 Mar 1877; note that this date is just before the primary school was relocated from this address in July.

⁸⁵ The Good Templars Hall was located on the east side of John Street between Alice and Albert Streets, not quite halfway up to Alice Street.

⁸⁶ MC 26 May 1877, 31 May 1877

⁸⁷ MC 6 Apr 1878

Prayer seems to have been the location of services for quite a considerable period, because four years later, in 1882, a visitor to Maryborough reported attending services in John Lane.⁸⁸

Early in 1883, Godson's 80th birthday was celebrated at the same Baptist House of Prayer in John Lane.⁸⁹ But in the course of events, some of the speakers complained about the lack of space in the building for the size of the regular congregation. So it was clear that the work of the church had recovered to a considerable degree, even though there were already moves afoot to commence a new Baptist church in the town.

The congregation had apparently maintained itself or even grown since the birthday event, because in June 1883, services were advertised for the Protestant Hall⁹⁰ as if a regular event.⁹¹ Then finally in July 1883 it was announced that a new Baptist church in affiliation with the Baptist Association of Queensland would be formed. It would meet in various hired premises until it erected a completely new building in Fort Street, opened on September 27, 1885.

So after about 20 years of services in a variety of locations and circumstances around the town maintaining the Baptist presence after the demise of the ill-fated Wilson-Hinton-Roberts effort, there are no more reports of any regular church services being conducted by Godson! But it had been a heroic effort by an elderly pastor which had won for him, for the most part, the respect of the town and recognition as its Baptist minister.

Other services

As well as the regular Sunday services in all these different locations, Godson also often took his church services out into public places, something that he had done often during his early ministry but, in contrast with those happier times, he sometimes encountered opposition in the Maryborough context.

In particular, there was one regular Sunday afternoon open air service held near the wharf in which Godson participated with others (including a Mr Foster, possibly a local photographer and temperance advocate) about which even the local press had to protest. A correspondent first drew the attention of the editor to the situation who agreed 'with a feeling of shame' when it was pointed out that 'insulting, obscene, or impious language' was used to disrupt proceedings. But the situation had escalated to threats of 'personal violence to Mr Godson', upon which the newspaper said, 'Would it be too much to ask that a constable make it his business to look around at those periods in order to ascertain the name of, and, if necessary, prosecute the parties so offending?'⁹²

But there were also more peaceful events such as a service on 3 October 1875 on the river bank near the public baths 'to welcome our new arrivals as per *Star Queen*' which had arrived from London via southern ports a few days earlier with about 290 immigrants on board.⁹³ The passengers had already expressed their appreciation of the efforts of the captain, surgeon and matron in letters published in the newspaper.

Some 13 years earlier, the first vessel bringing migrants direct to Maryborough from England, about 260 in all (about a third of the population of the town at the time⁹⁴), the *Ariadne*, had also been welcomed with two services in the Baptist Church in Lennox Street in October 1862. Rev WS Roberts led those services, and preached a welcome sermon, in which in a surprisingly modern manner, pointed out many practical aspects of the Australian culture drawing from his own experiences, and showing how the new arrivals could integrate into their new country and contribute towards its welfare!⁹⁵

Godson also wrote to the press giving information about services which he probably facilitated for the Polynesian indentured labourers in the district who met regularly in a chapel in Adelaide Street and in his own Baptist meeting house.⁹⁶

Baptisms took place, of necessity, in public places where a body of water was available, like a river or pool. But Godson was well used to this procedure from his earlier ministry, some examples of which were reported with warm approval from his ministry in the United Kingdom.

⁸⁸ *Queensland Freeman*, 15 Sept 1882

⁸⁹ MC 1 Mar 1883

⁹⁰ The Protestant Hall, which was owned by the Orange Lodge, was located on the north-east corner of John and Alice Streets (MC 28 Sept 1876)

⁹¹ MC 16 June 1883 and 23 June 1883

⁹² MC 21 Jan 1871

⁹³ MC 30 Sept 1875; 2 Oct 1875

⁹⁴ Rod Kirkpatrick, *Sworn to no master: a history of the provincial press in Queensland to 1930* (Toowoomba, Darling Downs Institute Press, 1984) p 32. The *Chronicle* said, 'We look on this day as the turning point in the history of Maryborough.' (MC 9 Oct 1862)

⁹⁵ MC 9 Oct 1862, 23 Oct 1862

⁹⁶ MC 20 Nov 1875

One of the earliest recorded took place in November 1848 at Tenbury, followed by three more the next month including a former Independent from the town of Ludlow, where it was observed there was ‘much inquiry ... respecting believers’ baptism’ initiated by the arrival of ‘certain respectable individuals who came to reside there.’⁹⁷

There was another on 9 June 1850, when ‘in the classical current of [River] Teme, at the Salopian entrance to Tenbury Wells’, the surrounding gardens ‘literally swarmed with spectators ... and probably the whole excited concourse exceeded the population of Tenbury and all its hamlets.’ The onlookers included ‘visitors of distinction and the elite of the locality’. There were two ‘respectable’ couples baptised, and ‘the whole affair was carried out with the greatest modesty and decorum’ by Godson, ‘for many years the much respected and highly gifted Minister of our Baptist Chapel’. He was ‘surrounded by a dense crowd of well-dressed and well-behaved young men’ and ‘delivered a most eloquent discourse’ on the well-known classic text, Matthew 28:19.⁹⁸ Another took place on 27 July 1851 where a ‘labouring man’ was baptised in the river close to town before a ‘great number of persons’.⁹⁹

On January 30, 1853, at Evenjobb, it was reported that ‘the roads leading to this village presented a lively aspect by the number of persons thronging to the Baptist chapel, where a large congregation gathered.’ Godson preached at the chapel and then led the people to a stream nearby to baptise a lady who ‘had been a zealous church-woman, but from reading the scriptures had been convinced of this duty [believers’ baptism].’ She had persisted in her desire for baptism despite ‘much persuasion’ against her to prevent the decision.¹⁰⁰

There were also reports in 1854 of Godson’s effective preaching in Gladestry, leading to the baptism on April 30 of a man who was ‘buried in baptism in the presence of a large concourse of well-behaved spectators.’ It was hoped that his example would be followed ‘by others, whose attention appears to be drawn in the same direction.’¹⁰¹

A later report, dating from January 1858, referred to crowds of people assembling near a river at Walton, Old Radnor, for the baptism of a young man. Godson stood on a chair near the river, under a tree (‘in the branches of which perched several boys’!) to lead the service. There was a ‘a goodly number of respectable persons who formed a very fair choir’ and there was a short address on the meaning of baptism. Godson was described as ‘a rather tall, middle-aged man ... with head uncovered, book in hand, in a long black gown.’¹⁰²

More than a year later, in May 1859, there was the report of another baptism at Ebbw Vale where, on a sunny Sunday afternoon, about 1000 people from many different denominations (including Catholic and Mormon!) assembled at ‘“a certain water,” near to our railway station’, which, the reporter noted, presented ‘an interesting panorama.’ The singing of hymns in this setting ‘gave peculiar effect to the service,’ and the large crowd ‘behaved most respectfully’. Four young men were baptised, and later at the evening service in Zion chapel at Briery Hill, they were received into membership of the church. Godson’s sermon at the baptism emphasised the uniqueness of Baptist witness over the course of Christian history.¹⁰³

So Godson was well accustomed to performing outdoor baptisms in ways that impressed his non-Baptist audiences. Therefore it came naturally to him to do the same in Maryborough, although the physical environment was far different!

Probably the earliest of these was the long-remembered outdoor baptism of the German couple who were immersed in the muddy Corporation Quarry in 1871. But Godson mostly used the river near the ferry which was very close to his home. It was also the site of the bridge when it was erected in 1876 (replaced by the current structure in 1896).

Another involved a member of the Polynesian group whom Godson assisted with their worship. The service took place in the afternoon of 21 Nov 1875 at the ferry site. The press reported, ‘The usual preliminary service having been held, Mr Godson and the convert walked into the river up to their knees and the former clasping the latter firmly by the hands and the collar deftly and skilfully immersed or “ducked” him.’ However, at this point, it was reported that the convert ‘with his clothes dripping wet’, ‘some of the Islanders indulged in shouts of laughter’. However, ‘their levity was speedily rebuked by the officiating Minister who sternly reminded them that “in hell there would be no laughing.”’ This time the press was not on Godson’s side – the reporter said, ‘Candidly I don’t think the cause of Christianity was advanced by this public ceremony’!¹⁰⁴

But Godson would not be deterred by this kind of comment. Another river baptism took place near the ‘new bridge’ on 28 May 1876, another of a young man on 6 Nov 1881, and yet another with two candidates on 27 August 1882.¹⁰⁵

⁹⁷ *Baptist Reporter and Missionary Intelligencer*, 1849 p 153

⁹⁸ *Worcester Journal*, 13 June 1850

⁹⁹ *Hereford Times*, 2 Aug 1851

¹⁰⁰ *Baptist Reporter and Missionary Intelligencer*, 1853, p 84

¹⁰¹ *Baptist Reporter and Missionary Intelligencer*, 1854, p 177

¹⁰² *Hereford Times* 30 Jan 1858

¹⁰³ *Hereford Times* 28 May 1859

¹⁰⁴ *Gympie Times* 24 Nov 1875

¹⁰⁵ MC 27 May 1876, 19 Nov 1881, *Queensland Freeman*, Sept 1882 p 14.

There was still another announced for 27 May 1883, but this time with the strange notice in the press, ‘The Rubric of the English Church will be strictly adhered to as regards Mode and Subjects.’¹⁰⁶ This seems to be a reference to the Church of England (Anglican) Prayer Book, but it is hard to see how Godson could possibly have subscribed in any way to the tenets of that body, unless he was trying in some way to ward off criticism! Unfortunately this was another occasion when Godson was subjected to ridicule by the crowd and by the press! The service ‘attracted a large and very irreverent crowd’ to the ‘old ferry approach’. The candidates were two women who ‘entered the river at that very muddy and uninviting spot’, and as they were ‘successively dipped in the opaque fluid the crowd indulged in immoderate laughter and unrestrained jeering.’ But the press report did not help – ‘As to whether the exhibition was in conformity with the practice of the Baptist Church in other towns, or calculated to advance the views of the adherents of that old body, we are not prepared to offer an opinion.’¹⁰⁷

Experiences like this must have hurt Godson immensely when he remembered the times in his earlier ministry when large festive crowds had attended such services in the rather idyllic setting of a Welsh river bank!

During the period of Godson’s time in Maryborough, there were about 25 burials of Baptist people in the local cemetery, some being conducted by Godson. Some of them were children, usually in sad circumstances – something with which Godson could have identified, having lost two of his own four children at a young age!.¹⁰⁸ As usual, Godson also made himself available to others outside the Baptist circle in their time of need. He had done this in his earlier ministry in the UK when he conducted the funeral of a young Bermudan man, assisting another person in the service who was described also as ‘a man of colour’ and ‘a native of British North America.’¹⁰⁹

One funeral service in Maryborough was particularly poignant. It took place on 30 April 1865 and involved a young man, a butcher named Leonard Veit, who died as the result of foolish accident caused by reckless driving while drunk in Lennox Street opposite the Church of England, not far from the Baptist church.¹¹⁰ Godson also preached at another sad memorial service on 31 January 1874 - this time for the death of a very recent emigrant, John Hatton, aged only 19, who died by drowning at the city baths.¹¹¹

He was also called on to participate in some funerals as chaplain to temperance organisation, No. 14 Hope of Maryborough Good Templars Lodge. The first of these took place in March 1875, and there was another later in the year, in October.¹¹² Perhaps the most important was on 30 July 1882 when he officiated at the large service for Mr GT Watson, former local businessman and generous benefactor of the movement.¹¹³

Godson residence

The first reference to Godson’s place of residence appears in the *Chronicle* of 9 June 1864 where an advertisement appeared offering to let ‘the cottage and garden *now occupied*’ by him (emphasis added). No location was given, but a few days later, on 30 June, a doctor, Angus J Mackay, announced that he had set up his shingle at ‘Thanet Cottage’, and stated that this address had been ‘lately occupied by Mr Godson’. The location was given as John Street.

Very soon after, on 14 July 1864, Godson was at another dwelling in John Street, which he named ‘Dovedale Cottage’ after an important building of that name in his home town of Blockley. ‘Dovedale’ was located in John Street, Section 72 Allotment 18, on the east side between Queen and South Streets not far from the Mary River.¹¹⁴ This was to be his home and ministry base for the next two decades. He was the sole regular occupant for most of the time. It was likely capable of holding small meetings, and was probably the property known after 1872 as ‘The Baptist House of Prayer’ or the ‘John Street (Baptist) Chapel’. It was later described as being in ‘a rather obscure part of the town’¹¹⁵ and is currently adjacent to bushland area which lies close to the Mary River south of Queen Street. However, it was in

¹⁰⁶ MC 26 May 1883

¹⁰⁷ MC 28 May 1883

¹⁰⁸ Burials details supplied by Dr R Smalley, Secretary, Maryborough Wide Bay and Burnett Historical Society, 10 Nov 2025.

¹⁰⁹ *Hereford Times* 28 Dec 1861 p 2

¹¹⁰ MC 29 April 1865. He left a wife and young family.

¹¹¹ MC 3 Feb 1874

¹¹² MC 16 Mar 1875, 23 Oct 1875

¹¹³ 31 July 1882

¹¹⁴ Now Lots 1 and 2 on RP857083, being 17 John Street and 8 John Lane (Museum of Lands, Mapping and Surveying, 9 Jan 2026). The area has changed dramatically since the 1860s due to the many floods from the nearby river, the most serious of which occurred in 1893; there were other high-level floods in 1955, 1974 and 2013. The Godson property was probably at about the 9.5 -10 metre flood level, which is about an average level in that area.

¹¹⁵ *Queensland Evangelical Standard*, 30 Dec 1876

Godson's times often extremely busy, and became well known as the base of his work, and the location of Baptist services and other activities for a considerable amount of time.¹¹⁶

The property was held in the name of his daughter Anne. Originally, it was owned by E Kitching and was purchased by Anne Godson on 7 May 1864. Anne, WT Godson's daughter, who travelled to Australia with him, married David Phillip White, a squatter of Maryborough, on 7 April 1864. Some years later, 9 June 1870, she took a mortgage on this property.¹¹⁷ After Anne's death in 1888, this property was assigned to her husband David Philip White.

On 14 July 1864, the newspaper carried an advertisement by Godson calling for tenders for the erection of two cottages. Two weeks later he was advertising these cottages as available for letting, complete with gardens, a good supply of fuel and good water nearby – both at low rental.¹¹⁸ According to municipal rate information, these two blocks appear to be sub-divisions of No. 18 allotment (in the name of Anne White) which were facing backwards onto John Lane. They would have provided an income stream for Godson, and were presumably built using capital that he brought with him from England.¹¹⁹

Next door to the main John Street property on the south side, closer to the river, Allotment 19 was held in the name of Jane EA Cane, nee Reading, who had married local saddler, Robert Cane on 22 April 1859.

Although these were two separate properties, presumably with typical cottages of the time on them, there was also a very close relationship between them. Jane Cane is frequently associated with the ministry and life of Godson, including his weddings where she is sometimes a witness, and his work with the Good Templars Lodge. She was also implicated in a slander case against Godson. Perhaps she acted as his house-keeper and secretary.

It is also possible that Godson moved in with the Canes, because in the slander case it was said that Godson was a lodger with the Canes. That evidence may not be very reliable, but has some measure of probability if Anne Godson moved out of his house following her marriage in 1864, allowing the father to turn that cottage completely into a ministry centre (known as 'The Baptist House of Prayer'). However, mitigating against that conclusion is the fact that four children of the Canes were reported to have been born at Dovedale rather than at the Cane residence (although the death of the third child, the daughter was reported as taking place at the Cane residence)! The birth of Godson's still-born grandchild to Anne also took place there.¹²⁰ Mrs Cane was listed as the rate-payer.¹²¹

When Godson retired to Gympie in 1885, the Canes would also make the move, where they all lived at the same address. The death certificate indicated that Godson died in his own home and the Canes were lodgers at his house, but once again, press reports suggested it was the other way around.¹²²

In 1885, after the move to Gympie, the rates of the old John Street property were paid by Robert Cane with Godson's name crossed out on the record. The property was apparently purchased by neighbours in 1888.

The Cane scandal

Whatever the arrangements between the two houses in John Street, there was certainly a close relationship between the two parties. It was one that finally erupted into a serious legal case affecting Godson's reputation, his ministry and the welfare of the Baptist church in Maryborough.¹²³

In March 1878, Godson took a certain Mr Caldwell to court to sue him for £200 (or nearly \$30,000 today) for slander. The issue was that Caldwell was alleged to have spread the story that Mr Cane came home one morning (date not stated) and found his wife in bed with Godson. The asserted slander had taken place in November 1877 after a gathering at the Good Templars Hall when Godson, with a witness, had challenged the defendant about whether he had made the statement. The defendant confirmed that he had made the statement, and that the information had come from his wife.

As soon as the alleged slander had become public knowledge, the Baptist congregation had diminished seriously, and the remaining few people, 6 or so in number, were meeting in Godson's home rather than any public hall, as previously. Also, Godson's income from his church duties had reduced drastically – from 15 shillings a week to only 5 shillings.

¹¹⁶ There is a reference in a RootsChat.com post, dated 7 Dec 2008 by 'Maddie', to a letter having been written from Dovedale dated 9 Sept 1864, but it has not been possible to contact the person posting this notice. That letter, if it still exists, would be interesting tangible evidence of the Godson's residency at Dovedale, Maryborough https://sites.rootsweb.com/~engblock/dovedale_end/dove_hse1.html.

¹¹⁷ MC 4 June 1870

¹¹⁸ MC 28 July 1864

¹¹⁹ This solution to a previously difficult problem was supplied very kindly and expertly by Dr Roy Smalley, Maryborough Wide Bay and Burnett Historical Society.

¹²⁰ MC 6 Dec 1870

¹²¹ MC 4 Nov 1880

¹²² MC 6 Dec 1870

¹²³ MC 21 Mar 1878

The church was essentially destroyed, and ceased using the Temperance Hall at the end of November 1877. Godson's income was then only about 2s a week.

The details of Godson's early ministry in Maryborough were presented to the court, including reference to the damning letter from Rev BG Wilson about Godson's supposed financial impropriety, and Godson's subsequent resignation from the pastorate of the church, followed by the use of the Aldridge store for services. It was also deposed that through the defendant's 'interference', Godson was deregistered as a marriage celebrant, although Godson still asserted that he had been 'regularly ordained according to Baptist rites and ... [was] still recognised as a minister of the denomination.'

He had conducted services in the Good Templars Hall in John Street up to the time of the alleged slander, where attendances averaged about 40 people. His marriage licence had also been restored (in 1875) upon 'requisition from members of the congregation'. Godson stated that he had lived in Maryborough for 15 years, but had never heard the alleged slander until early November 1877. He had been asked by the congregation to resign on account of the slander.

A witness, William G Smith, Inspector of Works, recalled he had been told by the defendant about the alleged incident, but did not remember the actual words used. Additionally, he stated that he had told someone else (name not given) about it all. He also said that Godson had approached him in early November to ask what authority he had for making such statements. Both Smith and Godson then approached the defendant about the matter, who confirmed the accusation. Another witness, Mr George Dight, a former member of the Baptist congregation, confirmed the drastic reduction in numbers and stated that he had heard the slander earlier, but was not aware of its exact content until early November.

Mr Swanborer, a witness for the defence, a farmer from Tinana Creek and formerly a member of the Baptist church, indicated that the congregation was about 12 to 16 in number, and that in 1876 the average income was 1/6d with rent for the room being 5s. He stated that he had left the church because of the rumours about the scandalous relations between Godson and Mrs Cane, but he had been party to the congregational requisition for the restoration of Godson's marriage licence in '1873 or 1874'.

The lawyer acting for Godson argued for 'damages as would amount to a substantial vindication of the plaintiff's character, who, as a clergyman, was specially entitled to protection against injurious reports'. He also reflected 'severely on the conduct of the defendant in reviving a rumour that was apparently dying out.'

The judge seemed to agree by summing up 'heavily against the defendant.' The jury agreed with a verdict of guilty, but the damages awarded was only one shilling, and costs 'on the lower scale only'.

Wedding ministry

Godson lost no time upon arrival at Maryborough in becoming registered as a marriage celebrant, this status being gazetted as soon as 27 April 1863.¹²⁴ His first wedding took place on 1 June 1863.¹²⁵

As the only Baptist minister in the town, he could not only offer a valuable amenity for his own people, but he also made it his business to extend this service to the whole community. In fact, he advertised his availability basing himself at his home in John Street as a kind of 'marriage centre' with a fee of one guinea a time, and a 'trifle' more when travelling elsewhere, including into the country.¹²⁶

This would, it seems, become a major source of income for himself, because, in practice, for much of his time as the Baptist minister in Maryborough there was probably no regular congregation or denominational organisation to see to his financial support. It was of course a useful function for the district because the government needed to have good arrangements to provide this service for the people. The only other option was the registrar at the Court House, civil celebrants not being an option at the time.

The threat by BG Wilson to cancel his marriage licence at the outset amounted to nothing as there was no denominational organisation at that time to control such matters. Individual ministers had the right to seek government registration for themselves. Godson not only ignored this threat but boldly advertised his services!

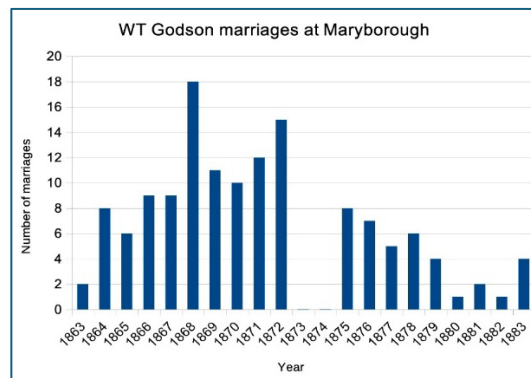
Godson's wedding services became perhaps his most well-known public ministry, and his weddings, sometimes multiple events on the one day, were reported regularly in the press. Weddings by other ministers were reported as well, but his seem to appear with the greatest regularity. Perhaps his most notable wedding took place on 29 September 1868 when he married John Nash, one of the Gympie gold prospectors to Miss Jane Demptser at Dovedale.¹²⁷

¹²⁴ MC 9 May 1863

¹²⁵ MC 11 June 1863

¹²⁶ MC 12 Nov 1863, 24 July 1880, 21 May 1881, 18 Aug 1883

¹²⁷ MC 1 Oct 1868



Godson claimed to have performed about 200 marriages during his time in Maryborough, and there were reports in the press of about 150 of them.¹²⁸ There was a steady flow all through the 1860s but only one in 1873, and none at all in 1874 when he was deregistered because of problems in the Baptist community. However, he was re-registered on 12 February 1875.¹²⁹ Sometimes there were multiple services on the same day, with the most being on 31 December 1868 which was reported as ‘the winding up of the Old Year at Dovedale’ when there were two weddings in the morning and another in the afternoon!¹³⁰ There were fewer marriages from 1877 onwards, so he advertised his services again in 1880, 1881 and 1883, with costs unchanged.¹³¹

There were no weddings after 1883¹³² when the Baptist church was re-formed in Maryborough, and a new series of ministers appeared in the city. There had been at least two other Baptist ministers in Maryborough at earlier times, but although one was registered for marriages, no ceremonies were reported; the other was an itinerant pastor. Godson finally notified the authorities in 1886 of his removal from the district which brought about the automatic loss of his authorisation on 8 February 1886.¹³³

About two-thirds of the weddings were performed at Godson’s residence, Dovedale Cottage in John Street, while others were done at various local venues including homes, hotels and other locations further afield. One was at Gympie, on 18 December 1867, which was remembered as possibly the first wedding in that town.¹³⁴

More than half of the weddings, about 80, were noted as involving people from overseas countries, including at least one couple just off the boat. The people were mainly from England or Scotland, but there were also some German, Chinese, American and even Polynesian people served in this way.¹³⁵ This phenomenon reflected the importance of Maryborough as an immigration port. Although dating to an earlier phase, it seems George E Loyau’s comment about the importance of a wedding ministry was apposite to Godson’s efforts. In his history of Maryborough, Loyau observed,

The arrival of immigrant vessels with nice girls (sic) gave opportunities for choosing eligible partners at parties and balls, for there was much fun after dark at Thacker’s Hotel, at Geo. Howard’s ‘Steam Packet,’ and at Durack’s, where the ‘light fantastic’ was kept up till the early hours of morn. *There were clerics who visited Maryborough from Gayndah and Brisbane, and one or two stationed here, who usually put matters right in matrimony and among these I may mention the Rev. B. G. Wilson, Baptist minister, ... who, with his colleagues, the Revs. J. T. Hinton and S. Wilson (sic), performed the marriage service for most of the Protestants who came together from 1850 (sic) to 1862; whilst the Roman Catholics had the ministrations of Dean Tissot from 1856.*¹³⁶

Loyau also noted that ‘Marriages were also performed by the Registrar, Stanley G. Hill, at the Court House, Maryborough.’

Being involved with so many couples through their marriages, it was not surprising that there were some unfortunate incidents which arose.

¹²⁸ MC 4 April 1878 p 2. The figure of 150 is the approximate number reported in the press, located via the digitised versions on Trove; the Paton document, ‘The Baptist Church in Maryborough, Q Time Line’, refers to 140, which must have been calculated by means of a manual search.

¹²⁹ MC 9 Feb 1875

¹³⁰ MC 2 Jan 1869

¹³¹ MC 24 July 1880, 21 May 1881, 18 Aug 1883

¹³² The last was Hill-Mossman/Grey on 8 Nov 1883

¹³³ It was registered in the *Queensland Government Gazette*, 8 Feb 1886.

¹³⁴ Hullyer-Lama, MC 28 Dec 1867, *Brisbane Courier* 12 April 1927 p 10

¹³⁵ MC 17 Oct 1871

¹³⁶ George E Loyau, *History of Maryborough*, (Brisbane, Pole, Outridge & Co, 1897), p 38ff (emphasis added)

The first, an unusual case, involved Godson only tangentially when his name was mentioned as allegedly officiating at a marriage of woman, Amelia Francis Cummings, who later successfully sued her actual husband, William George Cummings for desertion.¹³⁷

Another related to the inquest into the sudden death of Mary Ann Royston of Gladstone in 1873. She had been married by Godson at the age of 17 without parental consent, with Mrs Cane, who was thought by one of those giving evidence at the inquest to be a relative of Godson (and living with him) being a witness.¹³⁸

A potentially more serious case emerged in 1878, when James Berry was accused of bigamy, having already been married by Godson when he undertook a second marriage in Brisbane in 1872. Godson was called as witness under 'solemn affirmation' (avoiding the oath for reasons of religious conscience) and identified the defendant as a person whom he had married as a widower at Dovedale Cottage to Marian Evly on 23 October 1872.¹³⁹ The case was sent to the Circuit Court, but it was dismissed by a plea of *nolle prosequi*.

Another bigamy case occurred in January 1884 when Charles William Thompson was charged with this offence, as well as wife-desertion. He had contracted a second marriage in Milton in 1882. An aged Godson had to make an arduous visit to Brisbane to testify in court (again under solemn affirmation) that he had married Thompson and Elizabeth Mary Ann Adams at Dovedale Cottage on 15 December 1878. After a long delayed legal process, Thompson pleaded guilty in the District Court and was jailed for two years.

The final case was years later, in 1903, when Alfred George Whitaker petitioned for divorce from his wife, Sarah Ellen Whitaker nee Sheridan who were married by Godson at his John Street home on 17 October 1880 (not reported in the press). The case was undefended. There was a large family, but it was alleged that the wife had committed adultery in Maryborough with the co-defendant John Thomas Court while her husband was absent from home for long periods of time. The plea was granted.¹⁴⁰

Gardening

Over the years in Maryborough, Godson showed an interest in gardening, especially vegetables, drawing upon his experience from much earlier times while living as young man in Blockley.¹⁴¹ He probably used market gardening to supplement his income.

He sometimes brought plants into the city,¹⁴² and won prizes at the local agricultural shows for his exhibits.¹⁴³ In August 1870, the publishers of the *Maryborough Chronicle* reported that he had brought into their office a 'fine sample of ash-leaved kidney potatoes', which they believed was the first time this particular variety had been cultivated in the area.¹⁴⁴ In 1873, he advertised for lost geese,¹⁴⁵ and in 1869 he even made a financial contribution to the recently-formed Wide Bay Farmers' and Planters' Association.¹⁴⁶

Public life – the Temperance movement

Perhaps the most prominent public work, apart the weddings, in which Godson engaged was his involvement in the temperance movement. This was an important social movement in the late 19th century in Queensland, as in many other parts of the country.¹⁴⁷ The movement made its initial appearance in Brisbane as early as 1849, with the formation of a Moreton Bay Temperance Society, and later the Brisbane Total Abstinence Society (1859), which has continuous organisational links down to the present day. The movement enjoyed wide support for many decades in its crusade to deal with the serious problems in Brisbane brought on by unrestrained use of alcohol. This advocacy has since been extended to include other harmful drugs as well.

Over the years, many Baptist ministers and layman became involved in the movement, including Godson's colleague at Gayndah, Rev RR Wilson, who was applauded in his initial efforts to sign up many people to take the pledge. Rev BG Wilson was also a prominent advocate of the cause.

¹³⁷ MC 28 Jan 1873, 30 Jan 1873, *The Telegraph*, 3 Feb 1873

¹³⁸ *Rockhampton Bulletin*, 2 Oct 1873

¹³⁹ MC 4 April 1878

¹⁴⁰ MC 29 May 1903, 23 May 1903

¹⁴¹ Marriage certificate, 1838

¹⁴² MC 15 July 1865

¹⁴³ MC 24 July 1869

¹⁴⁴ MC 4 Aug 1870)

¹⁴⁵ MC 12 July 1873)

¹⁴⁶ MC 21 Jan 1869)

¹⁴⁷ Patrick Comben, *Queensland's Temperance Story: a Faithful Struggle* (Brisbane: DARFA, 2026) and personal information

The temperance movement in Queensland was promoted through many different organisations, but in time the focus was the Temperance Hall opened in 1869, after much difficulty, on land granted by the government in the prime location at the corner of Ann and Edward Streets, Brisbane. This building and its successor on the same site, the Canberra Hotel from 1928, served as the nerve centre for the movement in the state.

There were many different parts to the temperance movement overall, including several organisations both simultaneously and over time, ranging from advocacy associations, lodges with Masonic-style ritual and regalia, and Friendly Societies to provide financial benefits for members in times of sickness, accident and death. However, a statement made by the Bishop of London, Dr Frederick Temple in in the *Queensland Freeman* sums up neatly the overall aim of the Good Templars, but applies, *mutatis mutandis*, to the Temperance movement as a whole,

The distinctive characteristic of Good Templary was to induce men [sic] to abstain from intoxicating liquors, and to make a man [sic] feel that he was one of a band of brothers who were all pledged to make his life part of their life, to supply him with innocent enjoyment and social intercourse, and if he should wander to bring him back again.¹⁴⁸

These aims and objectives were carried out by regular meetings, erection and management of ‘Temperance’ halls in cities and towns across the country (which typically included libraries and reading, committee and function rooms), sponsoring of public meetings with speakers advocating the temperance theme, and later agitation at the political level for a local voice in the granting of hotel licences, known as ‘local option’. The Women’s Christian Temperance Union (WCTU) would later become a particularly important element to this movement at the political level. The more general term ‘temperance’ covers the entire movement, but after a few years at least, ‘*total abstinence* from intoxicating liquor’ was the norm, rather than merely temperance.

Godson gave himself to this work in Maryborough for much of the time he was there, and had in fact, brought the experience of many years in his earlier ministry to this work.

Godson stated in an address in 1874 that he had been a teetotaler for 40 years, which places him amongst the earliest supporters of that movement in the United Kingdom, with the first temperance society having commenced in 1833.¹⁴⁹

He had been listed as a ‘beer seller etc’ in his younger days at Blockley,¹⁵⁰ but had been converted to teetotalism in 1859 when he chaired a temperance rally held in Presteigne not far from Evenjobb, the county town of Radnorshire. He confessed at the time that he was not a teetotaler, although he had dabbled with the practice some twenty years earlier. But now, he had been impressed by the lecture and by the growing strength of the movement, so he signed the pledge admitting that ‘he did not think the balance [in favour of total abstention] would have turned [him] so soon’!¹⁵¹

True to form, he was reported as delivering open air lectures, along with the local Primitive Methodist minister, at Ebbw Vale in 1862 on the ‘cold water system’, and urging ‘every drunkard to sign the temperance pledge as being the safest and surest way to self-elevation’.¹⁵² Even as early as 1854 he had preached in the open-air against drunkenness and sabbath-breaking at a popular local fair.¹⁵³

There was a big surge of interest in temperance in the Ebbw Vale region around 1860 which was about the time he was living in that area.¹⁵⁴ So no doubt his convictions were strengthened even further at that point.

Before Godson had arrived in Maryborough his predecessor, Rev TJ Hinton had been a major figure in the establishment of a Total Abstinence Society (TAS), somewhere around mid-1860.¹⁵⁵ Another effort was made in early 1862 to revive this organisation. Hinton’s efforts were supported by his colleague in Gayndah, Rev RR Wilson, and his sponsor, Rev BG Wilson.¹⁵⁶ These efforts proved fruitless, despite some correspondence in the press supporting attempts to restart the organisation. There were no further developments until May 1870, when reports appeared of more attempts to revive interest. Finally, a public meeting was held on 29 June 1870 when the Maryborough Total Abstinence Society was (re-)formed. Godson was probably the first to sign the pledge on that occasion, and he regularly appeared at meetings for the first couple of years of this society’s life.

Efforts were soon made to acquire land and erect a Temperance Hall. Godson was an active supporter of the project. He probably facilitated a giant fair held over two days in the Theatre Royal fundraising for this project which proposed

¹⁴⁸ *Queensland Freeman*, Dec 1886, p14

¹⁴⁹ MC 1 Dec 1874

¹⁵⁰ *Bentley’s Directory of Worcestershire*, 1840, p54

¹⁵¹ *Hereford Times*, 5 Mar 1859

¹⁵² *Hereford Times*, 24 May 1862

¹⁵³ *Hereford Times*, 19 Aug 1854

¹⁵⁴ PT Winskill, *The Temperance Movement and its Workers: a record of social, moral, religious, and political progress* Vol III (London, Blackie & Son 1892), p138

¹⁵⁵ MC 30 Jan 1862

¹⁵⁶ MC 27 Feb 1862, 6 Mar 1862

a hall, free library and reading room.¹⁵⁷ He was chairman for a large tea-meeting in connection with this function held one evening in the Lennox Street Baptist church.¹⁵⁸ The hall was located in Richmond Street, and when opened on 28 January 1872,¹⁵⁹ proved to be a popular venue for functions, although the next year there were various complaints that the proposed reading room and library had not eventuated as quickly as expected.¹⁶⁰ One of the projects of the TAS in conjunction with the Grand Templars was to sponsor the formation of a Band of Hope in the town for the benefit of children.¹⁶¹

However, there were no more reports of any involvement by Godson with the TAS for many years after 1873, although the society did continue to operate (but perhaps without some of its early fervour and focus). However, he attended a Church of England Temperance Society function in 1882¹⁶² and he was listed as present at a TAS meeting in June 1885 when he was well over 80 years of age and in his 'retirement' phase.

In the meantime, Godson had turned his attention to the work of the International Order of Good Templars (IOGT), which first made its appearance in Maryborough in 1872 with the formation of Hope of Maryborough Lodge.¹⁶³ The Good Templars differed from the TAS in being a lodge, which involved the detailed masonic-like rituals and dress of such organisations, but one which was firmly based on the temperance pledge and promoted that movement. The IOGT also differed from the Protestant Alliance Friendly Society which made its first Queensland appearance at Maryborough, also in 1872, on 21 June.¹⁶⁴

The Independent Order of the Rechabites (drawing inspiration for its name from Jeremiah chapter 35), was a temperance-based Friendly Society offering financial benefits for its members in times of need, and was founded in Salford, Lancashire in 1835. It made its appearance in Australia as early as 1843, and also operated in Maryborough from 1874.¹⁶⁵

The Good Templars (IOGT) was first established in 1851 in New York State, USA, and then in Birmingham UK in 1868, from which it quickly expanded to British Empire countries with its temperance message and lodge rituals. The first Australian lodge of this order was established in Brisbane on 22 December 1871¹⁶⁶, after which the movement grew quite strongly (the Hope of Maryborough Lodge was number 14). As a statement in the *Maryborough Chronicle* explained, the Good Templars movement was open to both men and women, and was part of the great temperance league founded on the principle of total abstinence. It said that the weekly lodge meetings were 'seasons of moral, social, religious and intellectual enjoyment, our motto being Faith, Hope and Charity.'¹⁶⁷

For many years, Godson was 'Worthy Chaplain' of No. 14 Hope of Maryborough lodge, and as such often officiated at meetings and other functions at various locations and occasions. He was sometimes called on to carry out pastoral/ministerial duties arising from the connections, including some funerals. But he was also soon appointed to the role of District Deputy of the Worthy Grand Templar, a position which involved representing the state level of administration in the regions. This meant that he visited many other lodges in the area at official functions and especially to install officers and institute new lodges. One of these occasions was the inauguration of the IOGT Good Intent Lodge No. 5 on 13 November 1876, where he installed the officers, about 10 in number. The report of this function spoke in glowing terms of the value of membership in such an organisation.¹⁶⁸

He was still active in this movement in August 1877 when he was co-chair and made a long speech at a function held at the Primitive Methodist Church.¹⁶⁹ He was also on the platform at a function of the Rechabite Friendly Society No. 6 Tent at the Protestant Hall in 1883 when its well-known state secretary and later national leader, Mr Charles Fullwood, visited the town.¹⁷⁰

Godson also gave his support to the Loyal Orange Lodge in 1877 being on the platform to support a visiting American lecturer.¹⁷¹ Then on 13 July 1879, he gave a 'stirring speech' at a very well attended functions held at the Protestant Hall

¹⁵⁷ MC 26 Aug 1871, 30 Sept 1871

¹⁵⁸ MC 30 Sept 1871

¹⁵⁹ MC 25 Jan 1872

¹⁶⁰ MC 18 May 1872, 3 June 1873

¹⁶¹ MC 3 June 1873, formed in August 1872

¹⁶² MC 18 May 1882

¹⁶³ MC 11 July 1872, 13 July 1872

¹⁶⁴ Robert Cane, Godson's neighbour, was a foundation member of this organisation.

¹⁶⁵ *Brisbane Courier*, 26 Oct 1869

¹⁶⁶ *Brisbane Courier*, 22 Feb 1873

¹⁶⁷ MC 18 Nov 1876, *The Queenslander*, 22 Feb 1873

¹⁶⁸ MC 18 Nov 1876

¹⁶⁹ MC 1 Sept 1877

¹⁷⁰ MC 18 July 1883

¹⁷¹ MC 11 Oct 1877

in honour of the Battle of the Boyne.¹⁷² He made another appearance two years later at the same anniversary, delivering another memorable speech.¹⁷³

Godson was frequently a lecturer at temperance functions, including both the TAS in the earlier years and later the IOGT, as well as other bodies. He addressed the June meeting of the TAS on 'Progressive Development in connection with the Temperance Movement',¹⁷⁴ and the following year, he lectured at the Temperance Hall on the 'ethology of alcohol' (or as another report had it, the 'Aetiology of Alcohol') although the event had to be cancelled at first due to poor attendance because of bad weather. There was an appreciative, if small, audience when it was rescheduled later.¹⁷⁵ He was also one of the speakers at the fifth anniversary of the Protestant Alliance Friendly Society in 1877 at the Temperance Hall.¹⁷⁶

However, he was prone to speak at some length. His verbosity on one occasion drew the wry comment of the newspaper reporter, who said that Godson 'spoke for about an hour and dilated upon the mischievous effects of alcohol financially, physically, and morally'.¹⁷⁷

On another occasion Godson officiated at the Star of Peace Lodge No. 48 IOGT at the Primitive Methodist church and also addressed the meeting. The press report noted: 'When our reporter left, the Rev WT Godson had entered upon a speech descriptive of the advantages of temperance – which seemed likely to occupy the attention of his audience for some time, and as considerable portion of the programme then still remained to get through, we judge that the festive proceedings must have been protracted to a late hour.'¹⁷⁸

Other public duties

His name appeared on several occasions in the lists of donors to the local hospital, sometimes personally and sometimes on behalf of the Baptist community. Similarly he contributed to the support of the East Maryborough Primary School, and he was a member of the local committee of the British and Foreign Bible Society.¹⁷⁹

When there was a devastating boiler explosion at the Union Sawmill on 6 August 1872, he was one of those who voiced his concern, and gave practical support to the victims and their families. He preached in aid of this cause both in Maryborough and in the nearby localities of Pioneers Rest and Tiaro.¹⁸⁰ Further afield, his name was on the list of contributors for the relief of a famine in India.¹⁸¹ His name also appeared on the official guest list and organising committees for vice-regal visitations in 1871, 1873 and 1878.

Although a committed denominationalist, and more so as time passed, this did not prevent him from appearing at functions of other churches such as openings, anniversaries and social events. In 1880 he was a speaker, along with other clergy, at a service held to commemorate the centenary of the Sunday School movement which attracted 1400 people.¹⁸² He gave support to German and Polynesian congregations in various ways as well.

All this earned him the satisfaction of being known as 'The Baptist minister' in Maryborough during these two decades, despite the unusual nature of his ministry.

The spirited Godson

But despite this recognition and widespread community activity, Godson was not reticent in speaking up, even stridently, when he thought it necessary.¹⁸³ In 1875, he protested his innocence when the local press criticised him for making 'uncalled' for remarks at a public meeting by writing a strong letter – which the editor treated dismissively.¹⁸⁴

¹⁷² MC 15 July 1879

¹⁷³ MC 14 July 1881

¹⁷⁴ MC 22 June 1871

¹⁷⁵ MC 15 June 1872, 22 June 1872

¹⁷⁶ MC 8 Sept 1877

¹⁷⁷ TAS meeting on 15 Mar 1871; see MC 18 Mar 1871

¹⁷⁸ MC 1 Sept 1877

¹⁷⁹ MC 24 Nov 1874, 24 July 1878

¹⁸⁰ MC 15 Aug 1872)

¹⁸¹ MC 22 Nov 1877

¹⁸² MC 29 June 1880

¹⁸³ *Hereford Times*, 1 Nov 1862

¹⁸⁴ MC 2 Sept 1875

Locally, he drew the attention of the municipal authorities to the needs of the John Street area where he resided. In March 1869¹⁸⁵ he complained to the council about the lack of a culvert over a creek in Lower John Street – a severely neglected area of town - which did result, after some time, in a positive outcome.¹⁸⁶

Then in April 1874 he wrote to the council again about a ‘dangerous chasm’ in John Lane which, he said, was a severe risk even to horse-riders who would typically leave local hotels in inebriated states. A horse had been lost there due to the gaping ‘chasm’ which had not been fixed by the Council, and an ordinary working man had suffered financial loss thereby. His letter was not treated seriously by the Council - in fact it was considered an ‘insult’, because it was claimed to be ‘not respectfully written’¹⁸⁷ and it had been consigned, literally, to the waste-paper basket! So Godson responded with a sharp letter to the press protesting his innocence, pointing out that he had addressed the body properly by referring to ‘The Worshipful the Mayor and Aldermanity of this Town’ and asking, in all innocence, ‘What in the name of mightiness could I say more dignifying?’

The substance of the complaint was that the Council had received the request and had in fact agreed to fix the problem months earlier, but the absence of the mayor at the time was used by the Council as an excuse for inaction, which led to a further grave incident. Godson also had the temerity to state that if the hole in the road had been near the business interests of some councillors (such as the prominent White Lion Hotel, corner of John and Walker Streets), it would have been fixed immediately! Godson was not at all repentant for having forcefully brought this matter to the attention of the authorities because he feared yet another serious accident which could even end in loss of life. He ended by stating that, in the circumstances, his complaint was ‘Not uncourteous or [showing] want of respect.’

In November 1880 he took up Mrs Cane’s case when it was alleged she had not paid her rates,¹⁸⁸ and nearly two years later, he had to sue a certain Henry Meares over his failure to pay £4/10/- owed to him for some unstated debt.

These were serious enough cases in their context, but as early as 1864, he had responded to an issue of an entirely different kind. In the extra Monday supplement of the *Maryborough Chronicle* of 2 May, a notice appeared, signed by a Mary Sinfield, stating,

I do Not allow Mr. Godston (sic) or any member of his Church to Write Letters to my wife from This Date,
HENRY SINFIELD

In the next regular issue of the *Chronicle* dated 5 May 1864, Godson replied in a somewhat whimsical although trenchant way, pointing out, first of all, the error in the spelling of his name. Then he went on to wonder if he should have replied at all, or taken the advice of the book of Proverbs 26:5 and let the matter rest. However, he then noticed Proverbs 27:22 and so ‘was led to desist in despair.’

Giving the background to the incident, he described how he had recently baptised Mrs Sinfield (with the husband as a ‘spectator’), although, as per Acts 8:21ff, he had doubts about the genuineness of the lady’s faith. Then at a prayer meeting a few days later, both husband and wife seemed to be acting rather strangely (he wondered if it were ‘lunar or demonian’!), and to ‘evade interrogation,’ and ‘fearing she would be subjected to the discipline of the Church’, it was found that ‘their premises [home] were placarded with prohibitory notices’. Then the real issue emerged in Godson’s letter - Mr Sinfield had brought a single ‘serious’ charge against Godson ‘in the presence of credible witnesses’, viz, ‘that I had kept his wife under the water [in the baptism] too long.’ Godson defended himself by stating that ‘she was not under the water half a minute’. Clearly, he would not take fools lightly, even it involved sacred matters and some strong language! (2 Cor 11:19)

He also did not hesitate to express his views in public – in fact, 1864, he wrote such a long letter to the press on some unknown subject that the editors responded by saying that they believed he would agree ‘that we have wisely withheld it’!¹⁸⁹

Although none of these interventions was of critical importance, they reveal that Godson, even as a senior person and ‘unofficial’ pastor of the Baptist community which was in a high state of flux, had a strong sense of public duty. Perhaps this attitude was something that he learned during his earlier years in Ebbw Vale, Wales which was renowned as the seat of radical social views. In any case, it reflected well on Godson and his energy at that stage of life, and his determination to speak up on matters affecting his community.

¹⁸⁵ MC 6 Mar 1869

¹⁸⁶ MC 1 April 1869, 27 May 1869

¹⁸⁷ MC 16 April 1874

¹⁸⁸ MC 4 Nov 1880

¹⁸⁹ MC 25 Aug 1864

Travels

Godson did not travel a great deal in the local area. He was in Gayndah in February 1865 to celebrate the opening of the Baptist church, speaking at the opening itself and then at the regular church service. He also travelled there again in July 1867 to conduct the wedding of his young fellow pastor, Rev RR Wilson.¹⁹⁰

He was one of the early visitors to Gympie after it came to fame with the discovery of gold in 1867 and joined with other clergy in trying to provide Christian ministry to the chaotic booming settlement.¹⁹¹ He was also known to travel to nearby areas such as Pioneers Rest, Tiaro and Burrum (45 km north).¹⁹²

In 1871¹⁹³ he did intend to visit Bundaberg, which was then a small town on the southern banks of the Burnett River about 100 km north of Maryborough on its way to becoming a major sugar producer. However, there were some people there who did not welcome Godson because, as well as preaching, he wanted to deliver a lecture on temperance as a fund-raiser for the new Temperance Hall to be built in Maryborough. It is not clear if the visit was ever made.

Later in life he was obliged to travel to Brisbane to give evidence in a court case involving one of the couples whom he had married. He was absent 19 February to 1 March 1884.¹⁹⁴

But he did make two longer journeys – both to Mackay, 700 km north (not as far as Bowen, the town which he had contemplated visiting 15 years earlier). The first was made in July 1878, but there were no known engagements.¹⁹⁵ However, about the same time, he was involved in a court case regarding one of his marriages in which the accused was arrested in that city in April 1878, although the case was transferred to Maryborough.¹⁹⁶

Then several years later, on 15 February 1885, he was advertised to preach at the Good Templars Hall in Mackay,¹⁹⁷ having arrived a week earlier. He did not return to Maryborough until late March.¹⁹⁸ There is no information available about any local contacts who may have arranged such a visit. Years later, it was recalled that there was at least one loyal Baptist in the town at the time, Mr Robb, who was the first European to settle in the town in 1861.¹⁹⁹ A regular Baptist church was not commenced until 1958.

End of an era - 1880s

By the late 1870s, there were many other churches operating in Maryborough,²⁰⁰ but the closest Baptist church was at Rockhampton, about 400 km to the north. Although Rev JT Hinton, the founding pastor at Maryborough, had transferred north to that centre in the mid-1860s, he had long since moved on, and that church was busy enough with its own affairs not to show any interest in Maryborough. To the west, the Baptist church commenced in Gayndah in 1861 by Rev RR Wilson had closed with the end of his ministry in 1870 and the property was sold to the Roman Catholic Church.²⁰¹

In Brisbane, the pioneer pastor, Rev BG Wilson had died in 1878. Previously ill-health and other local matters had prevented him from continuing on to any effect his initial grand mission to establish churches throughout the colony. Neither his successor nor any of the several other pastors or churches which appeared in the intervening period had any ability or showed any practical interest in developing churches in the country districts, apart from a few outstanding centres like Townsville, Charters Towers and Mount Morgan. The only positive sign came from the enterprising Jireh Particular Baptist Church which had started an outreach in Gympie, no doubt under the leadership of the Kingsford family, which had established a branch of their successful drapery business in the town. However, reports late in 1872 indicated that that work had not succeeded.²⁰²

This lack of church planting and expansion was partially due to the fact that for more than two decades after the initial foundation of Baptist work in Brisbane in 1855, there was still no centralised denominational structure to take any

¹⁹⁰ David Parker, 'Baptists in Gayndah Queensland's oldest (?) town', 2025 <https://www.bhsq.org/pdf/Parker-Baptists-in-Gayndah.pdf>.

¹⁹¹ MC 25 Dec 1867; see also David Parker, 'The original Gympie Baptists—3 strikes' (2026)

¹⁹² MC 28 Aug 1877, 7 Sept 1876

¹⁹³ MC 23 Nov 71

¹⁹⁴ MC 20 Feb 1884, 21 Feb 1884, 1 Mar 1884, 3 Mar 1884, 4 Mar 1884

¹⁹⁵ MC 31 July 1878. It is assumed that the 'Mr Godson' mentioned in the shipping list is Rev WT Godson although that cannot be proven.

¹⁹⁶ MC 24 April 1878

¹⁹⁷ *Mackay Mercury*, 14 Feb 1885, 11 Feb 1885

¹⁹⁸ *The Capricornian*, 21 Mar 1885

¹⁹⁹ *The Queensland Baptist*, July 1925 p 6

²⁰⁰ MC 30 Dec 1876

²⁰¹ David Parker, 'Baptists in Gayndah Queensland's oldest (?) town', 2025 <https://www.bhsq.org/pdf/Parker-Baptists-in-Gayndah.pdf>

²⁰² MC 7 Dec 1872

initiative in matters such as church planting. By the late 1870s there were several churches in the metropolitan and country areas, but relations between them were purely on the basis of ad hoc family and church links, and sometimes strained. However, steps were taken in early 1877 to form a denominational organisation, and the Baptist Association was established on 18 October 1877 with seven member churches. News of this development was reported in the local Maryborough press,²⁰³ but there was no attempt at the time by either the Maryborough people or the Baptist Association to bring Godson or his church into the new organisation.

The first notice that Baptists had a presence in Maryborough appeared in the *Queensland Freeman*, the newspaper of the Baptist Association, in September 1881 when 'AC' from Rockhampton wrote reminding readers of the original hopes for the Baptist church in Maryborough (in the early 1860s), stating that

At the present there are a good many Baptist families in the town, who, owing to the want of a pastor (the Rev. Godson, being upwards of eighty years of age [sic], is consequently past work), have become scattered among other Churches, and many, if not all, of whom would rally round a minister of their own faith had they one in the town.

'AC' chastised the Baptists who were apparently too strongly focused on the Brisbane area to care about the country districts like Maryborough, Gympie and other 'western and northern towns of our colony'. He urged the denomination to take a far more missionary-minded approach with the hope of expanding the Baptist cause much further afield, especially in the growing towns.

Although being unaware of just what this 80-year-old pastor (!) was doing, a year later, another unidentified correspondent to the newspaper also complained about the lack of information relating to Baptist witness in Maryborough. But he, 'having espoused the principles of the Baptist Church, as being in strict concordance with the New Testament', reported he had visited the town fearing he would not find 'a fraternity of my own persuasion', but was pleasantly surprised to find 'a small meeting-house in John Lane', known as the Baptist 'house of prayer'. He said the hymns and tunes being sung made him 'quite at home', and that the 'minister, being an old man of apparently fourscore, was enabled to preach with earnestness and simplicity'. He was pleased to report that this 'was indeed to us a "feast of fat things"'. He went on to report that on 27 August 1882 there was a baptismal service on the river bank near the bridge when two candidates were immersed, and the sermon on Romans 6:4,5 was 'listened to by the large assembly with marked attention.' There was another such baptism in May 1883.²⁰⁴

Perhaps some of this publicity did have an impact because late in 1881, the *Brisbane Courier*,²⁰⁵ reported that the Baptist Association had rented the Primitive Methodist Church in March Street for three months where the respected successful pastor and then President of the Association, Rev William Poole, would be conducting services with a view to 'form or re-form a church.' It noted, 'Hitherto the affairs of this church have been in the hands of the Rev Mr Godson.' Services began on 13 November 1881. The *Chronicle* said²⁰⁶

Mr Poole, we are informed, is an excellent preacher, and we hope to see a crowded congregation greet him tomorrow. We believe there are a large number of Baptists in and around Maryborough, who have become scattered amongst the various churches, but who will, we have no doubt, rally to this call.

After his visit, Poole recommended further help be arranged, especially if a suitable pastor could be found. He said,

I venture to assert that if a man of fair preaching abilities, of an energetic disposition, of living faith, and spiritual-mindedness were permanently settled there, he would, before twelve months had elapsed, have gathered many a wandering Baptist home, won converts for Christ, and have around him a warm-hearted people ready for every good work.²⁰⁷

However, the Baptist Association said it could only offer practical assistance 'to help them *by and bye*',²⁰⁸ and accordingly, the services soon lapsed.

There is no indication of further official Baptist activity for nearly two more years until July 1883,²⁰⁹ when a notice appeared in the *Chronicle* indicating that 'a second Baptist church will be formed shortly, under the auspices of the Baptist Association of Queensland' and that an outstanding exit student from the famous Spurgeon's Pastors' College in London was expected to become the resident minister. The following month²¹⁰ it was reported that the 're-organisation of the Baptist Church' had progressed to the point where 'Pastor Godson, who has labored for many years, will give

²⁰³ MC 23 Oct 1877

²⁰⁴ MC 28 May 1883

²⁰⁵ MC 10 Nov 1881; see also MC 12 Nov 1881

²⁰⁶ MC 12 Nov 1881

²⁰⁷ *The Queensland Freeman*, 1882 p 3

²⁰⁸ Minutes, Baptist Association of Queensland, Executive Committee, January 1882 (emphasis added)

²⁰⁹ MC 25 July 1883

²¹⁰ MC 28 Aug 1883

place to a younger minister.' That pastor had already arrived in Brisbane and would begin his ministry Sunday 2 September 1883.

Another announcement²¹¹ noted that 'the Baptist denomination, so strong in other colonial towns, has not attained prominence in Maryborough, notwithstanding many adherents'. High hopes were set for the ministry of the new pastor, Rev WB Clinch, 'a young preacher of considerable talents and great promise' who, during a short stopover in Brisbane, 'created a most favorable impression, which will doubtless be confirmed in Maryborough'. He was in his early 30s. Opening services were conducted in the Temperance Hall on 2 September, to which 'The Baptists of Maryborough, and all friends, [were] cordially invited'.²¹²

However, the expectations for a successful ministry were dashed when only a few months later, the new pastor announced that he was leaving the Baptist denomination and joining the Church of England. The Baptist Association (and Spurgeon himself, to whom this defection was quickly reported!) were highly surprised, not to say annoyed, by this turn of events. However, arrangements were soon made for the temporary appointment of another minister, which kept the new church together. A permanent replacement was found in the person of Rev William Bonser who commenced a 9-year ministry in 1886. A new Baptist church building was opened in 168 Fort Street (just two blocks west of the original chapel) on 27 Sept 1886 at a cost of £650 (the cost of the land was £150), and this has continued to be the centre and basis of Baptist work in the city ever since.

Meanwhile, Clinch officiated briefly in the local parish of the Church of England, and then in Ipswich before leaving Australia for South Africa in 1886 where he served for a few years. He then returned to England where he died in 1933 after ministry in several different localities.²¹³

It seems as if reports that there were a considerable number of Baptists dispersed among the other churches in Maryborough might have been at least partially true. It was noted that the Congregational Church, first established in Maryborough in 1879, collapsed soon after the opening of the new Baptist church because, *inter alia*, of the loss of its Baptist attendees.²¹⁴ One of these was local businessman, TS Warry who after associating with other churches, became the initial and long-serving secretary of the re-formed Baptist Church

Continuation

About the time preparations were being made for the re-formation of the Baptist Church, celebrations were being held on 22 February 1883 to mark Godson's 80th birthday, at the John Street 'Baptist House of Prayer', which was gaily decorated for the occasion. The reporter noted that a plate was passed around to defray the expenses causing Godson to remark that 'making an appeal to a congregation for money was something new to him, as he was not aware of having received a pound for his services in years past' with reference to statement of the Apostle Paul, 'I seek not yours but you.'²¹⁵

At this time, Godson's church was still evidently in full operation because the gathering discussed the crowding of the chapel during services, and the lack of a Sunday School for the children. Action was suggested on both counts, and in June services were being advertised for the Protestant Hall.

By the end of the year, Godson was replaced as the Baptist minister in Maryborough after two decades of solitary and laborious ministry, but it was not the end for him. He conducted another wedding in August 1883, at Burrum, and advertised his wedding services again that same month. There were two more ceremonies - one at his beloved Dovedale Cottage on 7 September 1883, and another, his last, on 8 Nov 1883 of two people from Gympie. He was still involved in a legal case arising from one of his weddings, requiring an arduous trip to Brisbane in February 1884. In August 1884, he was reported seriously ill.²¹⁶

By now he had begun to show increasing interest in the matter of baptism, which appears to have occupied his mind more fully for the remaining few years of his life. There was yet another open-air baptism on 27 May 1883, which once more attracted an unruly crowd.²¹⁷

On 25 October 1884 he published an advertisement in the local newspaper offering a reward of £10 to anyone who could point to 'a Single Passage of SCRIPTURE on INFANT BAPTISM. (1 Peter 2-13 excepted)'. He would give half

²¹¹ MC 31 Aug 1883

²¹² MC 1 Sept 1883 – full report of both sermons on 8 Sept 1883

²¹³ Acknowledgement is made of the assistance of the Anglican Archives, Brisbane in supplying information about Rev BW Clinch, 27 Oct 2025.

²¹⁴ Loyau, *The History of Maryborough and Wide Bay and Burnett Districts from the Year 1850 to 1895*, p 306

²¹⁵ MC 1 Mar 1883; Godson had evidently forgotten about the generous gifts that had been given to him in 1873! (MC 9 Oct 1873)

²¹⁶ MC 26 April 1884. It was apparently not regarded as unexpected as 'The reverend gentleman has attained a good old age'

²¹⁷ MC 28 May 1883

that amount to the person presenting such evidence and the other half to the Lady Musgrave Hospital. He signed himself 'DISCIPLE GODSON, Maryborough'. There is no indication of any respondents!²¹⁸

This revived a similar challenge he had made 10 years earlier when he offered £50 reward for anyone 'who will shew the advertiser a single passage of Scripture on Infant Baptism.'²¹⁹ Again there was no indication of any response for this amount, which might be equivalent to more than \$7000 today!

Final chapter - Gympie

In February 1885 he made his long trip to Mackay, and June 1885 he was once more mentioned as participating in a temperance meeting at the Maryborough Total Abstinence Society meeting, which was his last.²²⁰

Then came the final chapters of his life.

He notified the General Registry Office in February 1886 of a change of address – he had moved from Maryborough to Gympie and taken up residence at Horse-shoe Bend, Gympie.

There was no Baptist church in Gympie at the time. An initial effort about 1870 assisted by the Jireh Particular Baptist Church which erected a chapel at the One Mile had failed.²²¹ The next attempt was made in 1887 by Rev William Bonser of Maryborough who began a building fund, but this came to nothing. It would not be until 1897 that a permanent church would be established.

This was not Godson's first link with Gympie. Known as Nashville up to 1868, Gympie was located 170 km north of Brisbane and about 90 km up the Mary River from Maryborough. It first came into prominence in late 1867 with the discovery of large amounts of gold, which, as well as creating boom conditions locally, gave a much-needed vital boost to the economy of the young colony of Queensland. By December, Godson was one of the several ministers who had visited the area to conduct services, and there was talk of the erection of a large multi-denominational church.²²² Many regular services were commenced the following year. Godson conducted the marriage of John Hullyer, late of Cambridge UK, and Flora Lama, of Gympie Creek, late of M'Cloud Scotland, at Gympie on 18 December 1868. This was still remembered as late as 1927 as being 'Just about the first marriage' in the town.²²³

Now in 1885, Godson had retired to that town. The Canes had also made the move, and they were all living at the same address. The Canes were later identified with formation of the Churches of Christ in Gympie at a meeting in their home on 8 August 1886. After gathering in public halls for a few months, a church building was erected at 9 Crescent Road and opened on 8 October 1887.²²⁴ The historian of the movement cites a 'W T Godson' as being one of the founders of the movement in the Gympie district, and that he was influenced by the many writings of Churches of Christ pioneers.²²⁵

Godson's increasing interest in baptism in the later years of his life may indicate his attraction to the then newly developing Restoration movement of which the Churches of Christ were the most notable examples in Australia. The fact that he signed his name as 'Disciple' in one of his baptism challenge advertisements lends weight to this assessment. The issue of the meaning and significance of baptism is one of the key differences between classic Baptist and Churches of Christ doctrines. It would, however, mark a significant change from his earlier position of being a 'Baptist Successionist' holding the belief that churches of the Baptist faith and order have existed in an unbroken continuous line, separate from other denominations, since the days of the New Testament.²²⁶

Finally a notice appeared in the *Gympie Times* 4 August 1888, stating:

Deaths: On August 1st, at the house of Mr Cane, Horse-shoe Bend, William T Godson fell asleep, aged 85 years.

²¹⁸ MC 1 Nov 1884

²¹⁹ MC 12 Sept 1874

²²⁰ MC 9 June 1885

²²¹ *Gympie Times*, 24 Aug 1872, MC 7 Dec 1872

²²² MC 25 Dec 1867

²²³ *Brisbane Courier* 12 April 1927

²²⁴ Geoff Risson and Craig Brown, *The Church from the Paddock' A history of Churches of Christ in Queensland 1883-2013* (2016 2nd edition), p 23 and photo of Tabernacle. The building still exists and is privately owned.

²²⁵ Graeme Chapman, *No Other Foundation: A Documentary History of Churches of Christ in Australia 1846-1990* 3 Vols. This link was located with via CoPilot 31/Dec 2025
https://webfiles.acu.edu/departments/Library/HR/restmov_nov11/www.mun.ca/rels/restmov/texts/gchapman/nof/NOF3B.HTM#Page388. No further details of what publications were read by Godson or how he might have contributed to foundation of movement were available even after personal contact with the author.

²²⁶ *Hereford Times*, 28 May 1859

The death certificate states that he died of ‘natural decay’, and noted that it took place in his own home, and that the death had been reported by Mr Cane who was a tenant!²²⁷

A service to honour his death was held at the Christian Church, Crescent Road on Sunday 5 August led by Charles Watt. The subject of the address was, ‘The Door was Shut’. He was buried at the Gympie Cemetery under the name William Thomas Godson.

His daughter, Annie, had already died on 28 March 1888 (born 1829) at Owanyilla, south west of Maryborough, from ‘chronic dyspepsia and general breakdown of constitution’ after an illness of six months. Her husband, David White, would live until 28 October 1906.²²⁸

Mrs Jane Cane died in 1899,²²⁹ and her husband, Robert, in 1920 at 83 years of age.²³⁰

In Memoriam

In later years, Godson was remembered in the pages of the *Queensland Baptist* as having baptised Mrs Cronan (who died on 15 November 1891) in the old clay pit in Maryborough, and for conducting what was probably the first marriage in Gympie.²³¹ However, apart from those fleeting references, the two decades of challenging but remarkably effective work of ‘the Baptist minister of Maryborough’ (as he was generally known in the town) usually only rates a brief mention in the history books as an insignificant, inconsequential and somewhat embarrassing interlude in the real history of Baptists in the town between the brief initial work of Hinton and its resurrection in 1883.

It is to be hoped that such a memorable and unusual ministry by a man decidedly in his senior years upon his arrival in the colony can now be given its due recognition as one of the many outstanding contributions that helped to create the Baptist and Christian history of this country, and that his name will be remembered as a dedicated pioneer and minister of the faith who saved the Baptist cause in Maryborough.

Acknowledgements

The main source of information about Rev WT Godson and the Baptist church in Maryborough used in this paper was the *Maryborough Chronicle*, *Wide Bay and Burnett Advertiser*, and, to a much lesser extent, other newspapers accessed via Trove, the online library database of the National Library of Australia, trove.nla.cove.au

Much of the information about property locations, buildings, burials and other general insights and local information was supplied by Dr Roy Smalley, PhD, Honorary Secretary, Maryborough Wide Bay & Burnett Historical Society, with additional information from the President, Anthony G Clift.

The Maryborough District Family History Society Inc supplied some maps and other information.

Particular detailed assistance on the Godson family in the United Kingdom and elsewhere was provided by Celia Dodd, compiler of the Godson Family History Newsletters, accessed originally at <http://www.greatervancouverparks.com/blockley.html>. Contact can be made by searching for ‘Godson’ at www.one-name.org

Jeanette Terry, who was introduced to the author by Celia Dodd, also provided extensive detailed documentary information and general background on the extended Godson family. This included, in particular, the following typescript documents:

“‘Dovedale’ – cottage’ and ‘The Baptist Church in Maryborough, Q Time Line’ compiled ca 2008, by Mrs ND Paton (believed to have been a resident of Toowoomba, Queensland, and drawing information from unknown sources)

‘William Jesse Godson – record of his Baptist Ministry’ (compiled 19 Sept, 2003)

‘William Jesse Godson about 1802 – 1888’ (compiled 19 Sept 2004)

‘Research done for Dell Paton by someone called Di in Australia’ (n.d.)

The Tenbury Museum provided details of Rev WJ Godson’s ministry in that town, the Tenbury Baptist church buildings and family details (<https://www.tenburymuseum.org.uk/>).

The Queensland State Archives was also accessed for various maps and property information.

²²⁷ So the relationship and living arrangements of Godson and the Canes was unclear, even at the end.

²²⁸ MC 29 Oct 1906. Anne’s death was registered under the name, Annie.

²²⁹ https://map.chronicle.rip/Gympie_Cemetery/plots/MPB%202%207?from=map&zoom=24&backTo=%2FGympie_Cemetery

²³⁰ MC 28 June 1920. He arrived in Maryborough about 1860 and established a saddlery and harness business, and was a foundation member of the Protestant Alliance Friendly Society in Maryborough.

²³¹ *The Queensland Baptist*, January 1892 p 10

The graph of weddings in this updated edition was supplied by Mr E Kopittke, Baptist Historical Society of Qld.

There are no specific papers from the Godson or the church of that period in the Baptist Church Archives, Queensland, but general information was accessed from this source

Assistance with interpreting and accessing maps and other data was kindly supplied by Historian, Thom Blake – <https://www.thomblake.com.au/index.php>

Others who provided assistance with supplying and interpreting data included: Eric and Rosemary Kopittke (BHSQ and Queensland Family History Society), Barbara Coe (Baptist researcher, Canberra, copy editing and data retrieval), Dr Pat Comben, DrugArm, Queensland, The Brisbane Catholic Archives and Ancestry.com

Other various sources are indicated in the notes.

There are no historic photographs available of any of the main buildings and sites associated with Rev WT Godson or the Baptist Church in Maryborough.

Abbreviation

MC *Maryborough Chronicle, Wide Bay and Burnett Advertiser* – accessed multiple times via Trove (NLA)

End